

DARREN GREGORY THE 9TH DELEGATE

KENYATTA UNIVERSITY SCHOOL OF EDUCATION

COURSE OUTLINE

Purpose of the course

The purpose of this course is to present the phenomenon of religion as a socio-scientific subject.

Course description

The course explore the development of the study of religion as a socio-scientific discipline. It presents religion as a phenomenon that manifests itself to the believers. Topics covered include: analysis of the concept of religion; theories of origin of religion; scientific study of religion; and theories that have shaped the current understanding and interpretation of religion, such as sociological, psychological, theological, feminist, anthropological, and philosophical theories. The course also presents an overview of religious experience in the era of internet technology.

Learning objectives

By the end of the course, the learners should be able to:

- Examine the concept of religion by identifying its components, distinguishing marks, as well as interconnections and interrelatedness between religions.
- Synthesize the various definitions and the theories of origin of religion.
- Apply the scientific method in the study of religious experience.
- Analyze the theories that have shaped the current understanding and interpretation of religion.
- Examine the effects of internet technology on religion.

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Instructional Materials and Equipment

Internet and E-learning materials

Text books

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COURSE OUTLINE & SCHEDULE

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INTRODUCTION

i. Why Study Religion

Religion is a great phenomenon in the world today and it has been so for as long as history can attest. Religion has influenced the rise and fall of empires e.g. the Roman Empire, the Greek empire and even the reign of the ancient Egyptian Pharaohs. Religion has also united many peoples and kept them knit together like in India (the Hindus) in Europe (Christianity) or Jews of the diaspora (Judaism). In Africa, traditional society has for long been revolving around the axis that is religion and Africans have been described as “notoriously religious” (Mbiti, John S. 1969).

In modern society, religion is a subject of interest and is studied keenly in world renown universities e.g. KU. It continues to influence many aspects of society e.g. economics (evangelism is said to be the fastest growing business in Kenya). Artistes of various aspects e.g. the gospel musicians are said to be basking in millions from their trade. Even those bringing in instability and insecurity in our society (e.g. the Alshabaabs) are pegging themselves and their ideology on religion.

These factors are adequate to demonstrate why it is important to study religion. Any student who wishes to understand the dynamics at play in the society today must study religion and its implications.

ii. Definition Of Religion

The concept of religion is intricate and it is very difficult to define it. Most Kenyan traditional languages lack a word that translates the word religion, yet as said earlier Africa is very religious. Western scholars have also differed in their quest to define religion with each group

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seeking to define it from their background e.g. sociologically, psychologically, phenomenologically, philosophically or historically.

The term religion is derived from the Latin word “religare” which literally means to “tie” together or to bind together. Religion is defined as belief in God or supernatural (spiritual) beings. That is a theological definition, and it is considered traditional and clouded with limitations, such as vagueness, narrowness and even prejudice (Hall Prilgrim & Cavanagh, 1986).

The problem of defining religion is demonstrated by the lack of agreement on the subject by the scholars. This may be a confirmation that there exists no universal definition of religion. We however need to look for a working definition of religion which can play the role of guiding learners to identify and collect data within human activities which may be included under the general heading of religious studies.

1. THE PHENOMENON OF RELIGION

1.1 Objectives



By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Have a clear understanding of the manifestations of religious reality.
- Discuss the various indicators of religion commonly referred to as “distinguishing marks” of religion.
- Compare and contrast the characteristics of chosen major world religions e.g. Islam, Christianity, Judaism, Hinduism and Buddhism.

1.2 Multi-dimensional Manifestations of Religion

Modern societies have by nature corrosive effect on traditional forms of religious life and lead to decline in the scope and influence in religious institutions and in the popularity of religious

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beliefs. Although modernity caused a degree of rupture between religion and society, there has also been a global revival of religion in the last two or three decades. In order to understand the transformation of religion and its comeback, various manifestations and expressions of religion must be analyzed. One's acceptance of and position towards a supernatural being, towards an ultimate reality and its manifestations involve a multidimensional process that includes attitudes, beliefs, emotions, experiences, rituals, and community and belonging.

Hill and Hood, 1999, argue that 'any construct as complex as religion is likely to be multidimensional in nature' because religion deals with people's ultimate concerns and provides both personal and social identity within the cosmic or metaphysical background'. Research on religious commitment supports this observation and indicates that religiosity is not a onedimensional experience in individual lives. This means that religious orientation has various dimensions.

One of the earliest theorists on the dimension of religiosity proposed a four-dimensional model in approaching religious orientation and religious group involvement. Lenski, from the point of view of the content, identifies these dimensions as follows: 1-the 'associational' dimension, which includes frequency of religious involvement in worship and prayer services; 2-the 'communal' dimension, which relates to the preference and frequency of one's primary-type relations; 3-the 'doctrinal orthodoxy', which refers to the intellectual acceptance of the prescribed doctrines of the church; and 4-the 'devotionalism', which involves private or personal communion with God through prayers, meditation and religious behavior. As these dimensions indicate, religious commitment has cognitive, relational, behavioral and ritualistic components.

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1.3 Distinguishing Marks Of Religion

For a movement to be a religion and for a group to constitute a church, it needs to manifest three characteristics, or marks, which are discernible in religions around the world.

First, a religion must possess a system of beliefs or doctrines which relate the believers to the ultimate meaning of life (God, the Supreme Being, the Inner Light, the Infinite, etc.).

Secondly, the system of beliefs must issue into religious practices which can be divided into 1) norms for behavior (positive commands and negative prohibitions or taboos) and 2) rites and ceremonies, acts and other observances (sacraments, initiations, ordinations, sermons, prayers, funerals for the dead, marriages, meditation, purifications, scriptural study, blessings, etc.).

Thirdly, the system of beliefs and practices must unite a body of believers or members so as to constitute an identifiable *community* which is either hierarchical or congregational in polity and which possesses a spiritual way of life in harmony with the ultimate meaning of life as

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perceived by the adherents. Not all religions will emphasize each of these characteristics to the same degree or in the same manner, but all will possess them in a perceptible way.

1.3.1 The Sacred and The Profane

Man becomes aware of the sacred because it manifests itself, shows itself, as something wholly different from the profane. To designate the act of manifestation of the sacred, we have proposed the term hierophony. It is a fitting term, because it does not imply anything further; it expresses no more than is implicit in its etymological content, i.e., that something sacred shows itself to *us*.¹ It could be said that the history of religions-from the most primitive to the most highly developed-is constituted by a great number of hierophanies, by manifestations of sacred realities. From the most elementary hierophany-e.g., manifestation of the sacred in some ordinary object, a stone or a tree-to the supreme hierophany (which, for a Christian, is the incarnation of God in Jesus Christ) there is no solution of continuity. In each case we are confronted by the same mysterious act-the manifestation of something of a wholly different order, a reality that does not belong to our world, in objects that are an integral part of our natural "profane" world

The modern Occidental experiences a certain uneasiness before many manifestations of the sacred. It is difficult to accept the fact that, for many human beings, the sacred can be manifested in stones or trees, for example. What is involved is not a veneration of the stone in itself, a cult of the tree in itself. The sacred tree, the sacred stone are not adored as stone or tree; they are worshipped precisely because they are hierophanies, because they show some thing that is no longer stone or tree but the sacred, the *ganz andere*.

It is impossible to overemphasize the paradox represented by every hierophany, even the most elementary. By manifesting the sacred, any object becomes something else, yet it continues to

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remain itself, for it continues to participate in its surrounding cosmic milieu. A sacred stone remains a stone; apparently (or, more precisely, from the profane point of view), nothing distinguishes it from all other stones. But for those to whom a stone reveals itself as sacred, its immediate reality is transmuted into a supernatural reality. In other words, for those who have a religious experience all nature is capable of revealing itself as cosmic sacrality. The, cosmos in its entirety can become a hierophany.

The man of the archaic societies tends to live as much as possible in the sacred or in close proximity to consecrated objects. The tendency is perfectly understandable, because, for primitives as for the man of all pre-modern societies, the sacred is equivalent to a power, and, in the last analysis, to reality. The sacred is saturated with being. Sacred power means reality and at the same time enduringness and efficacy. The polarity sacred profane is often expressed as an opposition between real and unreal or pseudoreal. (Naturally, we must not expect to find the archaic languages in possession of this philosophical terminology, real/unreal, etc.; but we find the thing.) Thus it is easy to understand that religious man deeply desires to be, to participate in reality, to be saturated with power.

1.3.2 The Supernatural

Within monotheistic religions, “god” (a term that is applicable here) is often perceived as the creator of all things, omniscient, and omnipresent. We see this demonstrated in the sacred texts of Western monotheisms such as the Hebrew Bible (Old Testament) or the Islamic Qur’an.

From the Old Testament: “By faith we understand that the universe was formed at God’s command, so that what is seen was not made out of what was visible,” (Hebrews 11:13). “The

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Lord is the everlasting God, the creator of the ends of the earth. He will not grow weary, and his understanding no one can fathom,” (Isaiah 40:28).

From the Qur’an: “Say: ‘O Allah! Creator of the heavens and the earth! Knower of all that is hidden and open!’”(39:46).

This account of god can be interpreted in two ways. First, god can be understood as exhibiting certain attributes of the infinite—he is everlasting, all-knowing, and all encompassing. In this way, one might understand god to be the embodiment of the infinite. Through this interpretation, prayer and scripture might be seen as a mechanism utilized to connect with the infinite through communication. Second, if one accepts the fact that god has created all things, then the infinite may be redefined as his creation—lending us a new discernment of the infinite. This idea would bring solace to believers by bridging the gap of understanding. In other words, rather than directly knowing or experiencing the infinite, the believer puts their trust in god who is the source of eternal space and time.

Hindu philosophy differs significantly from this perception of the “supernatural.” While Hinduism has several gods, eternal space and time stems from a construction that is markedly different from any deity. This construction is referred to as the “supernatural” Brahman. What makes Brahman significant is that it is a “transcendent nature” that acts as an embodiment of the infinite through which all things materialize. The Brahman is an ultimate reality that is supreme to all things; it is complete bliss. As the Upanishads state, “That supreme Brahman is infinite, and this conditioned Brahman is infinite. The infinite proceeds from infinite. If you subtract the infinite from the infinite, the infinite remains alone.”

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In this case, Hinduism offers a much more literal connection to the infinite than those found in the monotheistic religions. Hindu philosophy makes this connection possible through its doctrinal foundations of *samsara* (reincarnation- endless cycle of rebirths), *moksha* (liberation), and *atman* (the soul). The ultimate goal is to escape the cycle of re-incarnation by achieving *moksha*. When one achieves *moksha*, they have let go of their mind and body, and their *atman* or soul has become at one with Brahman. This *atman* characterizes their true selves (their inner soul) as indistinguishable from the Brahman. What this means in Hindu philosophy is that each person has a soul that is connected to a much larger ‘infinite’ and ultimate reality. Rather than acknowledging that the infinite is a concept far off and distinct from ourselves, Hindu philosophy suggests that each of us makes up a small part of this infinite, transcendent nature.

Each of these religions provides a medium through which believers can appease their psychological need for knowledge and understanding. By utilizing the “supernatural,” the religious person can explain the existence of the infinite, and foster a distinct comprehension of its nature. In the realm of western monotheism, god can be viewed as an adaptation of the infinite—a version of eternal space and time that believers can connect with through a communicative relationship. He can also be seen as the creator of the infinite, allowing the believer to justify his or her lack of understanding through the notion that god’s knowledge is beyond his or her own. Finally, Hinduism, supports that all souls are connected to the Brahman, and through *moksha* the soul is released into coexistence with the infinite.

1.3.3 Myths and Doctrines

The doctrines and dogma of Religion (including Bible Stories) forms the root of all our beliefs but are based on spiritual metaphors which were designed for a people of the time to put the mind in accord with the body and a person's way of life in accord with the dictates and

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experiences of natural order. Doctrine and dogma, the explication and officially acceptable version of a religious teaching. The development of doctrines and dogmas has significantly affected the traditions, institutions, and practices of the religions of the world. Doctrines and dogmas also have influenced and been influenced by the ongoing development of secular history, science, and philosophy.

Religious symbols and images are combined in the complex narratives known as myths. These forms have been illuminated by historians studying ancient civilizations and by anthropologists studying preliterate cultures today. In contrast to literary critics, who have usually concentrated on the internal content of myths, historians and anthropologists have been concerned about their place in the lives of individuals and groups. In broad terms, a myth is *a story which is taken to manifest some aspect of the cosmic order*. We shall for the moment postpone the question of the relation of the events narrated in the myth to historical events, and consider the function of myths in human life.

It can be seen that, when preconceptions and learned (or conditioned) beliefs are put to one side, there is another possible translation for the stories myths and legends of all of the world's Great Books. But, to do this, we must move beyond the doctrinal language traditionally associated with spirituality.

There are many examples of this close association of myth and ritual. New Year's festivals in several cultures are known to 'have included the *recitation and enactment* of creation myths. In ancient Mesopotamia, the victory of Marduk over Tiamat, the primeval dragon, was acted out annually; the New Year, as a new beginning, was celebrated as a renewal of the primordial victory of order over chaos. There was a close correlation of myth and ritual also in the 'mystery religions' of the Near East, such as Orphic, Eleusinian and Isis cults. The latter was a ritual

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dramatization of the Isis -- Osiris myth of death and resurrection, through 'which the initiate sought immortality. Again, the 'rites of passage' at critical points in individual life, marking a change of status (birth, puberty, marriage, death), are almost always accompanied by the presentation of myths. Initiation ceremonies and rites of purification and rebirth are rich in mythical symbolism.

If a myth is defined as a story in which some aspect of the cosmic order is manifest, then the *scriptures* of Judaism, Christianity and Islam must be said to include myths. For in them one finds stories of God's creation, judgment, deliverance, incarnation, and so forth; and these stories offer ways of ordering experience and patterns for human action and ritual re-enactment. In the western religions, myth is indeed tied primarily to historical events rather than to phenomena in nature. This difference is crucial for conceptions of history, time and ethics, but it need not lead us to deny the presence of myth in the Bible. Divine action is in itself no more directly observable in history than in primordial time or in nature.

1.3.4 Symbols and Signs

Religious symbolism is the use of symbols, including archetypes, acts, artwork, events, or natural phenomena, by a religion. Religions view religious texts, rituals, and works of art as symbols of compelling ideas or ideals. Symbols help create a resonant mythos expressing the moral values of the society or the teachings of the religion, foster solidarity among adherents, and bring adherents closer to their object of worship.

A religious symbol is an iconic representation intended to represent a specific religion, or a specific concept within a given religion. The Christian cross has traditionally been a symbol representing Christianity or Christendom as a whole. In the course of cultural relativism as it

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developed in the western world in the late 20th century, there have been efforts to design comparable "symbols" representing all of the world's religions.

Thus, the United States military chaplain symbols were limited to Christian and Jewish symbolism before the 1990s. In 1990, they were expanded by a wheel of dharma supposed to represent Buddhism, and in 1992 by a crescent moon supposed to represent Islam. Use of an Aum symbol representing Hinduism was in planning as of 2011.

Similarly, the United States Department of Veterans Affairs emblems for headstones and markers have been considerably expanded after a lawsuit was filed by Wiccans in 2006 (*Stewart v. Nicholson*). Until that time, the United States Department of Veterans Affairs (VA) recognized 38 symbols, including 16 variations of the Christian cross. In an out-of-court settlement, the VA accepted the inclusion of a greater variety of symbols, and as of 2013, the number of recognized symbols has risen to 57 (including a number of symbols expressing nonreligiosity).

1.3.5 Rites and Worship

Rite or ritual as we understand it today employs symbolism, in which representations of objects stand in for real objects, and ritual enactments of events stand in for real events. However, like language and art, symbolic ritual evolved gradually from a time before separation, when symbol and object were one. Very likely, the rituals of deep antiquity were an outgrowth of animal rituals of mating, dominance, and so forth, and were not symbolic at all, or at least no more symbolic than the songs of birds.

Rites only became symbolic when spirit became abstracted from physicality. That only happened when divinity became separated from nature, and that only happened when

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technology and culture created a separate human realm, especially when agriculture placed nature in an adversarial role. Wearing dualistic blinders, it is hard for us to imagine any ritual that were not symbolic, a ritual that is a real thing and not the representation of a story, principle, or event. So accustomed are we to asking what it means, what it symbolizes, that we can hardly conceive that the appropriate inquiry might be to ask what it *is*. We can hardly conceive of *understanding* something apart from interposing another level of interpretation between us and it.

Symbolic religious ritual is itself a mediation between two separately-conceived realms, the human and the divine. In the original religion, animism, there was no such distinction. Often misunderstood as the belief that everything has spirit, animism actually holds that everything *is* spirit, that everything is sentient, sacred, and special. Therefore, the abstraction of the particular embodied in language and number is, from the animistic point of view, a sacrilege, turning a continuum of unique places and moments into just so many things. Probably, even the purest animistic religions studied by anthropologists are already degraded versions of true animism, existing as they do in cultures that have already adopted representational language.

Primitive religion had a biologic origin, a natural evolutionary development, aside from moral associations and apart from all spiritual influences. The higher animals have fears but no illusions, hence no religion. Man creates his primitive religions out of his fears and by means of his illusions. In the evolution of the human species, worship in its primitive manifestations appears long before the mind of man is capable of formulating the more complex concepts of life now and in the hereafter which deserve to be called religion. Early religion was wholly intellectual in nature and was entirely predicated on associational circumstances. The objects of worship were altogether suggestive; they consisted of the things of nature which were close

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at hand, or which loomed large in the commonplace experience of the simple-minded primitive Urantians.

When religion once evolved beyond nature worship, it acquired roots of spirit origin but was nevertheless always conditioned by the social environment. As nature worship developed, man's concepts envisioned a division of labor in the supermortal world; there were nature spirits for lakes, trees, waterfalls, rain, and hundreds of other ordinary terrestrial phenomena. At one time or another mortal man has worshiped everything on the face of the earth, including himself. He has also worshiped about everything imaginable in the sky and beneath the surface of the earth. Primitive man feared all manifestations of power; he worshiped every natural phenomenon he could not comprehend. The observation of powerful natural forces, such as storms, floods, earthquakes, landslides, volcanoes, fire, heat, and cold, greatly impressed the expanding mind of man. The inexplicable things of life are still termed "acts of God" and "mysterious dispensations of Providence."

1.3.6 Revelation

The act of revelation is simply an unmasking or making known of that which was previously unknown. Though a fully articulated doctrine of revelation may not be present in the preenlightenment theological method, the idea of mediation, which is correlative to revelation, is unmistakable. Though the ancients did not expound the doctrine of revelation per se, their doctrines on man, sin, grace, atonement, and glorification necessitate mediation, which is one primary quality of revelation.

In the patristic thought, grace is revelation and revelation is grace. Herman Bavinck echoes this thought, 'All revelation, and especially that which comes to us in Christ through the Scriptures,

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is an act of God's grace, a free dispensation of His will, and a token of His undeserved and perpetually forfeited favour.' This patristic understanding informed the Reformers and those who would follow. God's revelation (often seen as a mediatory act) is intrinsically tied to redemption, and thus Downing's argument on purely eschatological revelation cannot stand the scrutiny of a closer study. How can eschatological revelation be possible if the path which leads to that eschaton can be navigated only by the gracious act of redemptive revelation? Our answer must be that God is knowable in our present state because He has chosen to reveal Himself. One of the few elements that world religions share is the assertion that humans don't live in harmony with the Ultimate Reality. In other words, humanity does not manifest its purpose of existence. Life is a far cry from the ideal claimed by religion, so that humanity needs salvation from its present condition.

1.3.7 Path to Salvation

In assessing the meaning of salvation in world religions we must analyze three important aspects: The resources needed for attaining salvation, the actual way of getting saved and the meaning of being saved. Concerning the first two aspects, some religions claim that salvation can be attained by using only inner human resources. They demand the use of meditation, accumulation of wisdom, asceticism, rituals, good deeds, etc. Other religions state that humans can be saved only through the grace granted by an external personal agent. This agent can be God, a *bodhisattva*, an *avatar*, etc. One's duty is to recognize the impossibility of being saved by one's own efforts, and therefore accept grace unconditionally. There are also combinations of these two ways.

Concerning the meaning of salvation from an eternal perspective, here too are important distinctions to mention. As emphasized in the previous article, the monotheistic religions state

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that the barrier between humans and God is sin. Salvation means removing this moral barrier and restoring a personal communion with God, which will endure forever. Pantheistic religions consider the human self to be one with the impersonal Ultimate Reality, and therefore humanity's problem is epistemological. Salvation means liberation from ignorance and the fusion of the impersonal self with the Absolute, of knower and known. Other Eastern religions, such as Buddhism and Taoism, take salvation as an illumination, meaning the discovery of and conformity of oneself with an eternal law that governs existence. Dualistic religions, which state that two opposed forces of good and evil rule our world, see salvation as a return to an initial angelic state, from which humans have fallen into a physical body.

Unlike the pantheistic religions of the East, the three monotheistic religions of the world - Judaism, Christianity and Islam - do not regard salvation as an impersonal merging with the Absolute, but as liberation from the bondage of sin and re-establishing a personal communion with the creator. However, there are some basic differences between them on how sin is to be overcome by humans, on the identity of Jesus Christ, the role he plays in salvation and what our attitude should be towards him.

Religions hold irreconcilable positions in the three aspects: the nature of the resources needed for attaining salvation, the actual way of being saved and the meaning of salvation from an eternal perspective.

The resources for attaining salvation belong strictly to our human nature according to most of the Eastern religions, excepting some schools of devotional Hinduism and Buddhism. Humans need only to know the right things in order to be saved, having the ability to pursue the religious path by their own strength. Christianity holds the opposite view, stating that our "true inner nature" is sin and therefore all our efforts aimed at earning God's favor are useless.

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As a result of the resources of human nature, the actual way of getting saved will take two divergent courses. Religions that claim we have all the resources in ourselves stress personal effort, realized as good deeds, devotional rituals, meditation techniques, physical asceticism, accumulating wisdom, etc. The situation in Christianity is again opposite, stating that we cannot do anything to deserve salvation and eternal communion with God, but must only accept his grace revealed in Jesus Christ. By no means can one have God indebted to him or her.

Therefore the course of action in salvation works in the opposite direction. It is God who takes the initiative and descends into his own creation in order to save us, not humans accumulating merits and working out their way toward God by their own strength.

The monotheistic religions define salvation as entering a state of eternal communion with God, which means that personhood will not be abolished but perfected. However, they differ greatly on the way one can be saved and on the role Jesus Christ has in it. According to Judaism and Islam, salvation is attained by performing good deeds and following the moral law. According to Christianity this is not enough and the role of Jesus Christ as Savior is essential. Given these facts, it is impossible that the world's religions could be only aspects of the same true spirituality, as present day syncretism suggests. The contradictions between them are so significant that there can be no way to reconcile them.

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1.4 Similarities and Differences among World Religions

1.3.1 Hinduism

Hinduism is the major religion of India. There alone over half a billion people are classified as Hindu. It has developed over 4,000 years making it one of the world's oldest surviving religious belief systems. Unlike most Western religions, it has no known single founder or creed.

However, all believers are committed to pursuing an ideal way of life, known as dharma.

Hindu society is broken into four classes, or castes. Each class has distinct duties and roles. The lowest class are the untouchables, who are considered inferior human beings. According to Hinduism, all moral beings are required to abide by honesty, courage, service, faith, selfcontrol, purity, and nonviolence.

One of the identifying features of Hinduism is a belief in the transmigration of the souls, or reincarnation. They believe the soul undergoes a cycle of rebirth and passes from body to body.

The body the soul moves into is determined by the goodness of a person's actions, known as karma. Hindus also believe in a multitude of gods who abide in the universe. In addition, everything is sacred in a Hindu's eyes. Therefore almost anything can be worthy of devotion.

1.3.2 Buddhism

Buddhism was founded in northern India about 500 B.C. by Siddhartha Gautama, the buddha. There are currently more than 300 million Buddhists in the world. Most Buddhists, however, have incorporated practices from other religions, especially Shintoism, Confucianism, Taoism, and Hinduism.

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Buddha taught that there were Four Noble Truths. First, all beings are caught up in maze of suffering. Second, the chain of suffering is caused by one's actions. Third, the suffering can be stopped. Fourth, ethical and disciplinary practices provide a way for the suffering to cease. By good acts, meditation, and developing enlightened wisdom, Buddhists believe they can achieve a rebirth in the heavens. This final goal of enlightenment is known as nirvana.

1.3.3 Islam

Islam is one of the world's fastest growing religions. Almost 1 billion people practice Islam with nearly 25 million converts per year. The term Islam is based on the Arabic word "al-am", meaning an unreserved committing of oneself to God. Those who commit themselves to Islam are called Muslims.

Islam was founded in Arabia during the 7th Century by Prophet Muhammad. Muhammad received divine revelations from Allah, via the angel Gabriel, and recorded them in the sacred book of Islam, the Koran. Although Islam's origins date back to the lifetime of Muhammad, Muslims regard their religion as a timeless religion of eternal truth. The line of prophets recorded by the Koran include Muhammad, Abraham, Noah, Moses, and Jesus. Muhammad is viewed as the ultimate restorer of the original religion of the patriarch Abraham. Islam also recognizes the Torah, the Psalms, and Gospel of Jesus.

Muslims trust and worship "the one and only God, Allah." Islam encompasses a way of life, a code of ethics, a culture, and a system of laws. The "five pillars" of the Islam faith are: (1) faith in God and the apostleship of Muhammad; (2) five daily prayers facing Mecca; (3) almsgiving; (4) fasting during Ramadan; and (5) a pilgrimage to Mecca. Muslims believe faith and works

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go together. On the Last Day, of which only God knows the hour, everyone will have to account for his deeds.

1.3.4 Christianity

Christianity is the religion of over a billion people whose belief system centers on Jesus Christ and the instructions of the Bible. To Christians, Christ was the Messiah promised by God in the Old Testament. Through Christ, sinners who believe in Him can be saved and receive eternal life.

Throughout the ages many doctrinal splits have occurred within Christianity. The Catholic Church dominated Christianity during the early centuries. However, the Reformation of the 16th century divided the Christian world. The Protestant movements which emerged now include Lutheran, Anglican, Baptist, Presbyterian, and other Evangelical denominations.

In the 20th Century, a strong Ecumenical Movement is attempting to work for total Christian unity across sects by stressing common ground among Christians. However, major differences in belief exist between Christian groups. Some do not believe in the second coming of Christ. Many believe the Kingdom of God is presently among the faithful. Most profess the doctrine of heaven and hell along with the three person godhead of the Trinity. Also, the majority of Christians keep Sunday as a day of worship and observe Easter and Christmas as celebrations of Christ's resurrection and birth

1.3.5 Judaism

Judaism claims over 14 million adherents around the world. It is the oldest religion in the

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Western world and is a common thread between Muslims and Christians. The basic source for Jewish belief is the Old Testament and specifically the first five books, known as the Torah or Pentateuch.

Jews believe their religion is valid for all time. According to the Old Testament, God or Yahweh, revealed his plan to the patriarchs. God entered into a special covenant with the ancient Israelites so that they could be an example to humanity of God's way of life. Judaism consists of a system of laws which includes adherence to dietary restrictions, monotheistic worship, a Saturday Sabbath, and observation of annual holy day festivals. The Jews believe in a prophesied Messiah, but most reject Jesus Christ as the Messiah. Jews have been severely persecuted throughout history for these beliefs.

1.4 Note



- Religious manifestations are universal.
- That most world religions originated in the Middle East or in the East.

1.5 Questions



- Discuss the seven distinguishing marks of religion.
- Outline the background and circumstances that led to the origination of three major world religions in the Middle East.
- Analyze the similarities between Hinduism and Buddhism.

1.6 Activity



- Pay a visit to a Hindu Temple, a Mosque and a Synagogue and get the attendant to give you a guided tour.

1.7 Further reading



Robert S. Ellwood, Jr., *Introducing Religion from Inside and Outside*. (New Jersey: PrenticeHall, Inc., 1978).

Kingston L. King, *Introduction to Religion*. (New York: Harper & Brothers Publishers, 1954).

2. THEORIES OF ORIGIN OF RELIGION

2.1 Objectives



By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the eight theories of the origin of religion and be able to place your traditional religion in the parameters of one or two of these theories.
- Appreciate other people's points of view in as far as the origin of their religion is concerned.
- Above all, understand the dynamics that create an enabling environment for the emergence of a religion.

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2.2 Fear as the Parent of Religion

Fear, a psychological phenomenon is often said to be the cause for the emergence of religion. This view is quite old, as old as the ancient Greeks and Romans. Ancient Roman philosopher and poet Lucretius contended that the belief in the gods was based on an illusion and that fear was at the root of religion.

David Hume, a British philosopher of the 18th Century, in his “Natural History of Religion” pointed out that a fear of natural forces led man to believe in gods who manipulated nature. Hence man felt and believed that gods would intervene in his behalf if he tried to please them. German scholar Max Muller also supported this theory.

According to him, the basis of religion is to be found in man’s awe in the presence of extraordinary and terrifying natural phenomenon. According to Prof. Giddings, the awe and fear of the “Great Dreadful” and of the mysterious forces have been responsible for the genesis of religion.

According to the celebrated psychologist Wilhelm Wundt religion is simply projection of fear into the environment, and according to Otto religion is identical with numinous feeling. Though Otto did not call this numinous feeling an emotion, other psychologists have identified religion with the sense of mysterious, the uncanny, and the sacred and termed it as numinous emotion.

As Bertrand Russell puts it “Religion is based primarily upon fear. It is partly the terror of the unknown and partly as the wish to feel that you have a kind of elder brother who will stand by you in all your troubles and disputes. Fear of the mysterious, fear of defeat, fear of death. Fear is the parent of cruelty, and therefore it is no wonder if cruelty and religion have gone hand in hand. It is because fear is at the basis of those two things. In this world we can now begin a

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little to understand things, and a little to master them by help of science, which has forced its way step by step against the opposition of all the old precepts. Science can help us to get over this craven fear in which mankind has lived for so many generations. Science can teach us, and I think our own hearts can teach us, no longer to look around for imaginary supports, no longer to invent allies in the sky, but rather to look to our own efforts here below to make this world a fit place to live in, instead of the place that the churches in all these centuries have made it.”

2.3 Religion as wish-fulfilment

Is God really there? Or is our sense of his existence nothing more than a secret hope that our greatest longings might be fulfilled? Is God for real – or is he just an illusion, like a dream in the night? These questions have long been debated within western civilization. In recent years, however, the idea that God is simply some kind of human wish-fulfilment has gained credibility, and is increasingly used in anti-Christian propaganda. The two writers who are especially associated with this development are Ludwig Feuerbach (1804-72) and Sigmund Freud (1856-1939).

Feuerbach's chief work is *The Essence of Christianity* (1841), in which he argues that the idea of God arises understandably, but mistakenly, from human experience. Religion in general is simply the projection of human nature onto an illusory transcendent plane. Human beings mistakenly objectify their own feelings. They interpret their experience as an awareness of God, whereas it is in fact nothing other than an experience of themselves. God is the longing of the human soul personified.

We yearn for a being that will satisfy all our desires and dreams – and, by doing so, invent such a being. For Feuerbach, the doctrine of the resurrection of Christ is nothing more than an echo of the deep human longing for immediate certainty of personal immortality. Scripture tells us

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that God created human beings in his image; Feuerbach declares that we have made God in our image. 'Man is the beginning, the center and the end of religion.' God is a human wish fulfilled and sustained by an illusion. Christianity is a fantasy world inhabited by people who have failed to realize that when they think they are talking about God, they are simply disclosing their own innermost hopes and fears.

What are we to make of this approach, which is developed in so significant a direction in the writings of Karl Marx? A number of points need to be made. First, the context in which Feuerbach develops his ideas needs to be examined. Feuerbach was writing in the heyday of the great German liberal theologian Friedrich Schleiermacher (1736-1834). Schleiermacher's theological system rests upon an analysis of human experience, supremely the experience of being dependent. Whatever the undoubted merits of this approach might be, it has the effect of making the reality of God dependent upon the religious experiences of the pious believer. Theology becomes anthropology, as an understanding of God becomes reduced to an understanding of human nature.

2.4 Theories Based on The Nature of Primitive Religions

Theories of the nature of primitive religion have moved between two poles: one intellectualistic and rational, the other psychological and irrational. Tylor and Frazer, who saw primitive religion as characterized preeminently by a belief in magic and unseen forces or powers, represent the intellectual or rational position. Tylor, for instance, based his interpretation of primitive religion on the idea that primitive people make a mistaken logical inference-an intellectual error. He thought that they confuse subjective and objective reality in their belief that the vital force (soul) present in living organisms is detachable and capable of independent

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existence on its own. Dreams, he thought, might be a basis for this error. Tylor's definition of primitive religion as animism, a belief in spiritual beings, expresses his interpretation that the basis of primitive religion is the belief that detached and detachable vital forces make up a suprahuman realm of reality that is just as real as the physical world of rocks, trees, and plants.

An opposing interpretation of primitive religion comes from an experimental and psychological approach to the data. R. H. Codrington's study *The Melanesians* (1891), in which he described the meaning of *mana* as a supernatural power or influence experienced by the Melanesians, has provided a basis for other scholars to explain the origin and interpretation of primitive religion as rooted in the experience by primitive peoples of the dynamic power of nature. The most prominent interpreter of this point of view was the English anthropologist Robert R. Marett. Variations of this theory may be seen in the works of Lucien Levy-Bruhl, who distinguished between a logical and pre-logical mentality in analyzing the kind of thinking that takes place through this mode of experience, and the writings of Rudolf Otto, who described the specific religious meaning of this mode of human consciousness.

Another rationalist approach to primitive religion is exemplified by Emile Durkheim, who saw religion as the deification of society and its structures. The symbols of religion arise as "collective representations" of the social sphere, and rituals function to unite the individual with society. Claude Levi-Strauss moved beyond Durkheim in an attempt to articulate the way in which the structures of society are exemplified in myths and symbols. Starting from the structural ideas of contemporary linguistics, he argued that there is one universal form of human logic and that the difference between the thinking of primitive and modern people cannot be based on different modes of thought or logic but rather on differences in the data on which logic operates.

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2.5 The High-God Theory

The term "High God" is used by historians and anthropologists to designate the supreme deity found in many polytheistic religions. How is this "High God" understood? He is usually described as being located somewhere beyond the sky; utterly transcendent, he is removed from the world that he originally created - hence the term "high". It is, to some extent, almost deistic in its concept.

According to the *Encyclopedia Britannica*, there is an African proverb that describes the High God as follows:

"God is on high and man is below. God is god and man is man. Each is at home; each in his own house."

Generally speaking, the High God has been conceived of as masculine by primitive societies. Furthermore, he is considered to be the sole creator of heaven and earth. But after creating the universe, he withdrew from what he had made and went somewhere else to live.

No images are made of the High God, and there is little if any religious activity associated with him. Essentially he is un-worshipped: few if any prayers or sacrifices are given. Why? Because he either 1) no longer cares or 2) because he already hears and sees everything and therefore there is no reason to talk to him.

If the High God is ever invoked, it is only under the most extreme of circumstances, and there is no great expectation by anyone that such a prayer will be heard or reacted to.

Usually, the name and myth of the High God are secret and revealed only to initiates.

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Frequently he is referred to as Father. He is generally conceived in one of three ways; either as 1) a transcendent principle of divine order; 2) a senile or impotent deity who has been replaced by a set of other, more active and involved gods; or finally 3) he has become so remote, having removed himself so far from human affairs, that he is all but forgotten.

Massive evidence, according to the *Encyclopedia Britannica*, has been collected among many peoples since the discovery in the 19th century of an unsuspected belief in "one supreme being, All-Father" among the Kurnai in Australia. This discovery revolutionized modern scholarly understanding of primitive religion in two ways:

First, many of the peoples which had been thought to have no concept of religion at all were discovered instead to embrace belief in a single, all powerful deity. In fact, such peoples actually had a sophisticated religion, but it simply lacked public rituals. The theology in such cases was esoteric and in general it was something that was not to be spoken of to outsiders.

Many reports, therefore, of primitive religions, had been limited to the observation of the external details of cult practice, but the existence of the High God challenged the adequacy of such reports and suggested that, in many cases, if the observer himself had not been initiated his report was not to be trusted.

Secondly, and of even greater significance, the discovery of the High God concept among primitive peoples challenged the popular 19th century theory of the evolution of religion from animism (belief in souls in humans and other aspects of nature) to polytheism to monotheism. Instead, a devolutionary approach seemed to be the more reasonable.

Obviously, the question arises, why and how do so many disparate and unrelated tribes and groups have such a similar and basic belief about a High God? Two things come to mind as

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Christians. One, and perhaps the most obvious, would be the thought that at one time, since all human beings are descended from Adam (and then, later, from Noah), in the hoary mists of antiquity, there was a time when belief in only one God was universal, since Adam and later Noah had immediate contact with and knowledge of Him.

A second, and less obvious reason for it derives from general revelation. Paul writes in Romans of the sense that all human beings have of the divine, and that therefore all human beings are without excuse - that is, none can legitimately say to God "I didn't know; I didn't hear". The Psalmist writes that "the heavens declare the glory of God."

In the same way that the laws of physics are universal and universally known, at least on a basic level, so too, morality and the concept of God are likewise universal and universally known, at least on a primitive level. In the same way that all societies have families and regulations for sexual conduct, forbidding adultery, or forbidding murder and stealing, so too, no more nor less than gravity is a universal concept, so the knowledge of God is also universal. Because he designed and built this universe, because human beings are created in the image of God, it is impossible to escape some basic, simple knowledge of him. The author of Ecclesiastes wrote, "God has set eternity in the hearts of men."

2.6 Magic As The First Form Of Religion

The question of the relation between magic and religion has often been discussed by anthropologists, and has an important bearing on the problem of the origin and nature of religion. In dealing with this relationship many questions inevitably arise. Have we sufficient grounds for assigning logical or chronological priority to the one rather than to the other? If so,

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to which of the two does priority belong? Can we place a genetic relation between them? Did the one spring from the other, by way of development or else by way of relapse? Or did they have independent origins? In an attempt to answer these questions at least three positions have emerged.

The first position holds that religion was prior to magic, or, in the words of Dr. Jevons, "that belief in the supernatural (religion) was prior to the belief in magic, and that the latter whenever it sprang up was a degradation or a relapse in the evolution of religion. This doctrine of relapse implying that man started with a relatively pure form of religion, recurs in other contexts in Jevon's book, for an instance he holds that polytheism is a relapse from a kind of monatheism. This view, however, has few, if any, supporters among modern antropologists , Andrew Lang's theory. He is an exception at this point. He set forth the theory that spiritual intuition rather than magic accounted for the rise of religion. He sees primitive monotheism as the root of religion out of which animism and myth grew

A second position holds that magic was prior to religion, and that the latter evolved in some way out of the former. Sir James Frazer is the outstanding exponent of this view. His famous theory may be thus briefly summarized. "In the evolution of thought, magic as representing a lower intellectual stratum, has probably everywhere preceded religion." At first man sought adjustment through magic, but "a tardy recognition of the inherent falsehood and barrenness of magic set the more thoughtful part of mankind to cast about for a truer theory of Nature and a more fruitful method of turning her resources to account." Thus man's bitter experience of the failure of magic drove him to a different and better method of dealing with the unseen. "The age of magic" gradually gave way to the "age of religion." In a word, man's despair of magic is the genesis of religion.

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Frazer's theory has proved quite suggestive and thought provoking. But, though doubtless it contains elements of truth, it cannot be accepted in the sharp antithetical way in which he presented it. As Edwards laconically states, "It is far too intellectualistic a view of the origin of religion. It seems to represent early man (of the more 'sagacious' type) as almost a full-blown arm chair philosopher in search of a working theory of life and the world, and ignores the spontaneous emotional response to environment which played a much greater part in the life of primitive man than reflective thought did." Further, the theory only offers a negative explanation of the genesis of religion--the failure of magic. A positive motive for religion still needs to be found.

A third position maintains that magic and religion had a common root in man's experience of the mysterious forces of the world, but that in the course of human evolution they revealed their mutual incompatibility even to the extent of active hostility. In this theory, then, religion and magic are thought of as issuing out of common conditions, being the results of man's more or less conscious experiments with the unseen powers in his keen struggle for existence, and of his endeavor to utilize the mysterious potency around him which is generally called mana to help him in the battle of life. This, as indicated above, is the view accepted by most modern anthropologists, and from my way of thinking it is quite valid.

2.7 Totemism

It was Durkheim's further conviction that on just this point—finding a specimen of a truly simple civilization—recent researches provided a remarkable breakthrough. We have already

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noted how in the years just before and after the turn of the century, Frazer took an interest in the work of Baldwin Spencer and F. J. Gillen, two field anthropologists who had been able to observe closely certain primitive aborigine tribes in the remote hinterlands of Australia. Their work—along with that of the German fieldworker Carl von Strehlow and others who had made similar observations—furnished a detailed portrait of social life in these extremely simple communities. And quite remarkably, it had also shown that the religion of these peoples was none other than totemism, the very same thing that so captivated Robertson Smith, Frazer, Freud, and other early anthropological inquirers.

Durkheim was no less fascinated than the others by this new Australian research, but he was also convinced that none of these earlier theorists had grasped its full importance. None had really appreciated how fundamental to primitive culture totemism really is. All recognized, for instance, that tribal peoples divide themselves into different clans, each of which is identified with a separate totem animal, plant, or other object. And all noticed that the totem itself, whether it be the bear or the crow, the kangaroo or the tea tree, is considered sacred to the clan that claims it. But none had detected the genuinely important thing: how totemism impressively illustrates the concepts of the sacred and the profane.

In each of these primitive societies, Durkheim observes, animals other than the totem, which are profane, can ordinarily be killed and eaten by the clan; the totem animal cannot. Because it is sacred, it is absolutely forbidden to the clan—except on those select occasions when, as a part of specially designated ceremonies, it is ritually sacrificed and eaten. In addition, the clan itself is regarded as sacred because it is considered to be one with its totem. And perhaps most important, the emblem, or logo, of the totem animal is always extremely important; it is not just sacred but the very model, the perfect example, of a sacred thing. When the clan gathers

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together for its ceremonies, it is always the totem symbol, carved into a piece of wood or rock, that holds center stage. The totem is supremely sacred and communicates its sacred character to all around it.

Totem beliefs, moreover, are so fundamental to the life of these simple societies that everything of importance is ultimately shaped by them. One can hardly find anything more basic than the very categories of human thought and experience; among the aborigines, these are provided by totemism. For example, totemic concepts govern their most basic perceptions of nature, so that not only groups of people but the entire world of natural objects is divided into categories based on totem clans, or clusters of clans, called phratries. One tribe, for example, places the sun in the clan of the white cockatoo, while the moon and stars are assigned to the clan of its black counterpart. In addition, natural objects are placed in a hierarchy of power, which could only have been devised on the basis of the levels of authority which primitives experience first in the structures of the family and clan. The concepts of the totem and the clan thus find their way into every significant aspect of tribal life. There are even cases of individual totems—those which a clan member can choose as a sort of personal friend—and sexual totems, which group people by gender. Both of these undoubtedly derive from more basic and general clan totems and offer further proof of their central importance.

In casting about for explanations of totemism, earlier theorists have followed their own quite predictable paths. Tylor, as we might have guessed, insists that the custom arises out of animism; others have thought that it derives from nature worship; and still others, like Frazer, have claimed that it is magical, or that it may have no connection at all to either religion or magic. Where all of these theories go wrong is, for Durkheim, not hard to see. Each attempts to trace totemism to *something else* that is supposedly earlier and more fundamental. But this

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is a crucial mistake. Finding a form of religion older than totemism is quite impossible, for the simple reason that *there is none*. Totemism, which appears in the very simplest societies, is itself the simplest, most basic, and original form of religion; all other forms can only grow out of *it*. Totemism is not a product, not a derivative of some more basic form of religion; it is itself the source from which all other kinds of religious worship—whether it be of spirits, gods, animals, planets, or stars—ultimately arise.

It is true that at first glance totemism seems to be merely another of the usual religious types: a kind of animal or plant worship and nothing more. But Durkheim insists that when we look at it in detail, it turns out to be something considerably different. Followers of totem cults do not actually adore the crow, the frog, or the white cockatoo; they commit to the worship “of an anonymous and impersonal force, found in each of these beings but not to be confounded with any of them. No one possesses it entirely and all participate in it.” If we want, we can of course speak loosely of a “god” adored in the totem cult, but “it is an impersonal god, without name or history, immanent in the world and diffused in an innumerable multitude of things.” Durkheim prefers that we speak more accurately of something called “the totemic principle,” which stands at the center of all of the clan’s beliefs and rituals. Behind the totem is an impersonal force that possesses enormous power, both physical and moral, over the life of the clan. People respect it; they feel a moral obligation to observe its ceremonies; and through it they feel tightly bound to each other in deep and abiding loyalty.

Here we can see why Durkheim thinks it misleading, at least at the outset, for theorists to define religion as belief in gods or supernatural beings. In hievew, before we ever get to belief in gods, there is always this first and more basic thing, the sense of a hidden, impersonal, and powerful force—the totemic principle—that is the original focus of the clan’s worship. It is significant,

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moreover, that the evidence we find for this totemic principle is by no means limited to Australia. Under different names, Durkheim claims to find it as well in other tribal societies. Among the Melanesians, there is the similar concept of *mana*; and among various American Indian tribes, we find the same principle described in such words as *wakan*, *manitou*, and *orenda*, all of which convey the same idea of an all-pervading, impersonal force, a dominating power, which is the real center of clan or tribe worship. It follows, then, that if we want to account for religion, we must explain more than surface beliefs in the gods or spirits that people routinely worship; we need to explain this more fundamental reality. We must show what this worship of “the totemic principle” really is.

2.8 Animism

According to the great anthropologist Edward Tylor, religion had its origin in primitive man's belief that non-physical substances like soul inhabited the physical and inanimate objects like stones, trees etc. Animism, derived from the Greek word *Anima*, meaning soul, is a belief in the non-physical, trans-empirical substance existing independent of body.

This fact was seen confirmed by dreams in which man saw somebody talking to him, who had died recently. Thus dreams convinced the primitive man of the existence of spirits and this conviction became, according to Tylor, the basis of religious beliefs.

Durkheim contends that a close look at the leading theories of the day will show a common theme throughout: all claim that religion is simply a natural instinct of the human race; it is assumed that in all cultures people have devised their systems of belief as quite logical responses to the world as they encounter it. The most prominent of these theories are the naturism of Friedrich Max Müller, whom we met in our introduction, and the animism of E. B.

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Tylor. Müller holds that people came to believe in gods by trying to describe the great objects and events of nature—things like the sun, sky, and storms. Tylor, as we have seen, holds that belief in gods developed out of the idea of the soul. Now in framing these views, Durkheim observes, both of these thinkers have been exceedingly ambitious. They have assumed that human society has gone through a long process of evolution, and they have then tried to travel backward in time to imagine what the ideas and emotions of the very first human beings would have been. But this is really an impossible enterprise.

If we truly want to be scientific about religion, we cannot rely on guesses about how people thought at the dawn of history. We must try to look instead for “the ever present causes” on which religion rests, the things that at all times and places push people to believe and behave in religious ways. Instead of making a grand guess about the distant past, Durkheim proposes that we look firsthand at a real example of religion in action. And for this purpose, what better method could there be than to locate the simplest society we know of and rely on someone who has actually observed it? A religion linked to the simplest social system that exists might well be regarded as “the most elementary religion we can possibly know.” And if we can explain this religion, we have a start on explaining all religion. We will have in hand religion’s “elementary forms.”

2.9 Pre-animism

Any satisfactory theory of the origin of religion must be able to account, not only for the prominence of magic and mysticism in religion, but also for the connection of these, from the beginning, with a vital moral element. Recent anthropology tends more and more to find this satisfactory theory in the conception of mana. Here the origin of religion is found in a preanimistic period or stage characterized by a sense of awe in the presence of a diffused,

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indefinable, mysterious power or powers not regarded as personal. This potency has been given many names, but for the sake of uniformity we may call it mana, as the Polynesians do, amongst whom this potency as such was first discovered by modern investigators. It is believed that mana is everywhere, intangible and all-pervasive.

All things have it: of course this does mean that mana is something universal or of abstract reality--the primitive has not risen high enough to generalize a universal reality--but it means that there is potency in every object to which man's attention is given. Mana by no means has any moral quality. It may be good or bad, favorable or dangerous, according to time or place. Here, then, we seem to have the common root of magic and religion. Here is an attitude of mind which supplies religion with its raw material. It is obviously more primitive in character than animism, and may be assumed to be chronologically prior to it. It "may provide the basis on which an animistic doctrine is subsequently constructed . . . Of such powers (towards which awe is felt) spirits constitute but a single class among many; though, being powers in their own right, they finish a type to which the rest may become assimilated in the long run. Religion in its origin is thus seen to be a sense of awe and mystery in the presence of the indefinable and incalculable power manifested in things, persons, and events, together with the attendant effort on man's part to adjust himself negatively and positively to that power, with a view to satisfying certain felt needs of his life.

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2.10 Note



- The High-God theory of the origin of religion cuts across most if not all religions.

2.11 Questions



- Discuss Bertrand Russell's theory that 'religion is based primarily upon fear.' ○ What role was played by Totems in the expression of African Traditional Religion?
- "Among the Luo people of western Kenya, a large snake like the 'Omieri' could be a crawling spirit" comment.

2.12 Activity



Discuss with your elders on the possible habitation of the living-dead in your society.

2.13 Further reading



John S. Mbiti., *African Religions and Philosophy*, Heinemann, Nairobi, 1969.
Robert S. Ellwood, Jr., *Introducing Religion from Inside and Outside*. (New Jersey: PrenticeHall, Inc., 1978).
Kingston L. King, *Introduction to Religion*. (New York: Harper & Brothers Publishers, 1954).

3. THE SCIENTIFIC STUDY OF RELIGION

3.1 Objectives



By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand the importance of studying religion as a science.
- Know the various scholars who pioneered this angle of studying religion.
- Conceptualize the real motives for studying religion scientifically.

3.2 Meaning Of “Scientific Study Of Religion”

The academic study of religion is sometimes called “the scientific study of religion” or simply “the science of religion” (Religionswissenschaft). Smart (1973) has defined the scientific study of religion as “an enterprise which is aspectual polymethodic, pluralistic, and without clear boundaries. Having given that definition, Smart proceeds to explain what he means as follows;

It is aspectual in the sense that religion is to be treated as an aspect of existence. Men behave and react religiously, and this is something the study of religion picks out: just as economics picks out the economic behavior of people. The study of religion is polymethodic in the sense that differing methods or disciplines are brought to bear on the aforesaid aspect. Thus one needs to treat religion by the methods of history, sociological inquiry, phenomenology, culturally, economically, politically and so on. It is pluralistic because there are many religions and religious traditions. The study of religion is without clear boundaries, for it is not possible or realistic to generate a clear-cut definition of religion. Indeed the whole enterprise of studying religion can justifiably be called ‘the science of religion’ (Penner and Yonan, 1972).

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Sharp (1975) has quoted someone as asking rhetorically: “if there is science in all things, is there no science in the dispensation of God?” Etymologically, the English word “science” is derived from the Latin word “scientia” which in other words means knowledge or epistemology.

Thus, the word “science” in its current usage, does not merely mean ample knowledge fortified with numerous facts, but also knowledge that is systematized. The systematization of knowledge necessarily involves the accumulation of facts. According to Brand (1959), the facts thus accumulated formed the basic data for classifying, analyzing, and comparing. From such classifying, analyzing, and comparing, emerge a series of general laws or hypotheses or theories which are relevant and essential to the interpretation and advancement of knowledge. These general laws or theories constitute, therefore, “the content of empirical science” or “the sum total of statements rationally inferable from observation and experiment. Hence, the fundamental philosophy of “comparative religion”, according to Muller (1973), is that he who knows only one religion, knows none, and can therefore make no judicious general statements or theories about even the one religion which he knows, let alone about the phenomenon of religion in general.

The method described so far for acquiring, systematizing, and advancing knowledge (scientia) through the process of accumulating, classifying, analyzing, and comparing the data (facts) and arriving at general theories or conclusions about the subject or object of study, is what is usually described or referred to as “the scientific method” of investigation in any discipline. This method has now come to be embraced by a new science – the science of religion – which is more than two centuries younger than the scientific method itself. Thus, the academic study of religion or “the science of religion,” claims to comply exactly with the scientific method.

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3.3 Reason For Studying Religion As Science

Science can objectively examine all the "earthly" manifestations of religion: the institutions, the rituals, the texts, the symbolism, psychological effects, the traditions, myths, etc. Indeed, we can examine the beliefs themselves and determine if evidence exists to support these beliefs.

But it's because religion is such an "important and pervasive phenomenon in human society" that it *should* be studied (Dennett 2006).

Another reason to study religion is to reach a consensus about what religion actually is. The definition I provided in the *Definitions* post certainly doesn't do the term justice. Guthrie notes that definitions imply theories and that there simply are no good theories about religion (1993). Anthropologists have their definitions; sociologists have theirs; believers of various religions have various independent versions; philosophers yet another; and so on. Even within these groups there is much disagreement about what constitutes a "religion" or "religious thought."

There are, however, two main positions when it comes to religion: that of believers and that of non-believers. The positions of believers are primarily central to their own religious beliefs and typically discount other positions as inferior. As Guthrie puts it (1993:8), to them, "belief must precede understanding" in many cases and that "these theories primarily concern some single, ostensibly true, religion, not religion in general.

The methodological implications of the motives that under lie the study of religion and more particularly, the academic study of religion have not received the attention they deserve. They are of the utmost importance, however, for the differences of motivation between the study of

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religion legitimated by the modern University and the scholarly study of religion that antedates it, sponsor radically different, if not mutually exclusive, approaches to its study.

When we talk of the motives, we classify them as missionary motive, vocative motive whereby a vocative religious scholar is subdued subjective, pre-conceive ideas and face objectivity; a study for the betterment of the individual concerned and ultimately, is concerned with salvation. There is also the recognition of the psychological, cultural and political roles religion has played in society and of its continuing importance in these respects, in terms of tolerance, harmonious living, peaceful co-existence and development not overlooking its dysfunctional roles in our own context seems for many to imply that the study of religion ought to be undertaken as support to religion in its manifold tasks—that is, that it ought to complement religion. It deals with historical fact that aims such as these have emerged in the development of Western culture.

There is no assumption here, that is, of the *sui generis* character of such systems of experience and belief and consequently no argument for the recognition of, say, *magiewissenschaft* as a new discipline or call for the establishment of departments of magic or astrology. The postulation of the *sui generis* character of religion but character of religion but not of magic, it appears, rests on the uncritical assumption that religion, in some fundamental sense, is true while magic (astrology, etc) is not.

The academic or scientific study of religion is simply one of several special areas into which the scientific vocation of which Weber speaks is organized and that, like the others, it seeks self-clarification and knowledge of interrelated facts.

The motive for studying religion must base on academic, that is, purely intellectual/scientific reasons and not as instrumental in the achievement of religious, cultural, political or other ends. This means, quite simply, that the academic/scientific study of religion must aim only at

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understanding religion where understanding is mediated through an inter-subjectively testable set of statements about religious phenomena, and religious traditions. As with any other scientific enterprise, therefore, the academic study of religion aims at public knowledge of public facts, and religions are important public facts.

Religion it must be recognized, is a form of human activity and therefore like any other form of human activity can become the object of human reflection. According to Wiebe (1985), this does not of course, imply that persons who are religiously committed cannot be scientific students of religion or, for that matter that Marxist atheists ought to be excluded from departments of religious studies. That institutional commitment is a kind of epistemic morality a commitment to what can reasonably be called “the morality of scientific knowledge”. ‘Morality’ here does not refer to the moral effects scientific knowledge may or may not have the uses to which scientific knowledge be put-as important as that may be, but rather the behavior required for the achievement of the goal of public knowledge of public facts.

The goal of the academic study of religion, therefore, to reiterate, is an understanding of the phenomena/phenomenon of religion contained in scientifically warrantable claims about religion and religious traditions. All the simplest logical level the student of religion functions somewhat like the scientific naturalist with a concern ‘to collect’, describe and classify the phenomena observed.

The range of data, obviously, is enormous, involving rites, rituals, beliefs, practices, art, architecture, music, and so on. Some departments of perspective in the descriptive accounts is provided in relating it to the field of events and structures of which it is a part; in comparing it to similar phenomena in other cultural and social contexts; and in providing at least a narrative account of its emergence and historical development.

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Though knowledge of religion at the descriptive level is richly informative, it is not primarily that for which the student of religion strives. Indeed, an increasing flow of such information soon inundates the individual for it is simply not possible for any one person to know all the particulars of the world's religious traditions. If these are the aims or motives of the academic of study religion then that study is structurally indistinguishable from other scientific undertakings. The academic study of religion is, then, a positive science and not a religious or metaphysical enterprise in that it concerns itself with religion as a public fact and not a divine mystery.

The study of religion that appropriately finds its place within the university curriculum is that that deals with a critical study of a human cultural phenomenon and not a quest for some ultimate meaning or truth. It seeks 'objective' knowledge of particular aspect of human culture. It is, therefore, essentially a positive, (not positivistic) social scientific endeavor that, although not necessarily behavioristic is nevertheless behaviouralist in its approach to religion in that it attempts to provide a public rather than a private knowledge (Comstock, 1981). It is the search for "objective" knowledge gained-free of presuppositions for its own sake alone.

3.4 Historical Background Of Scientific Study Of Religion

In 1859, Charles Darwin published the Origin of Species, where he described the process of evolution by natural selection, a theory that was to become the foundation of all life sciences. During the next half-century, Darwinian theory had a profound influence on the study of religion, and provided a guiding theoretical framework for its coherent scientific study, allowing for the first time for the real focus of this study "to be located, not in transcendental philosophy, but in... this-worldly categories" (Sharpe 1986: 24).

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Meanwhile, the cultural evolutionist theories of such scholars as Auguste Comte, Thomas Malthus, Herbert Spencer, and Lewis H. Morgan, were developed independently. Certain forms of this early cultural evolutionism were used to defend contradictory ideological perspectives including racist, colonialist and imperialist practices, laissez-faire economics, slavery, eugenics, and Nazi propaganda. These simplistic notions of social progress sought support in the Darwinian theory of evolution, on the basis not of scientific evidence but of political and ideological agendas. After World War I, when the critique of cultural evolutionism became widely accepted, social scientists radically changed their approach to the study of human societies, placing an emphasis on cultural relativism, in an attempt to avoid the ethnocentrism of past approaches.

Scholars of religion turned to less rigorous phenomenological treatments of religion, which averted theory and favored hermeneutic over explanatory approaches. Religion was considered as a sui generis domain, neither connected nor reducible to any other level of human behaviour. (e.g. see Otto 1923; Eliade, 1991; Sharma, 2001; Pals 1987). According to this view, the study of religion requires special and unique methods that are not available to the other disciplines. As Wilfred Cantwell Smith put it (1959: 42), “no statement of religion is valid unless it can be acknowledged by that religion’s believers”. Explaining religion would be to “explain it away”, or would miss its “essence” (whatever that may mean); therefore, scholars of religion should try to understand and describe rather than explain the object of their study (Pyysiäinen 2004).

Consequently, this view considered the study of religion as the exclusive privilege of theologians or – at best – as a pursuit strictly limited within the Humanities. By denying the authority and the right of scientific theoretical thought to examine religious phenomena and rejecting the usefulness of science for the explanation and interpretation of religious action and behavior, (McCutcheon 1997), it has effectively isolated the field and alienated scholars from

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other disciplines. Thus, religion generally remained strictly a subject matter of the Humanities and either embraced the hermeneutic stance or was mainly concerned with the social functions of religion and ignored psychological processes and the properties of the individual brain/mind. Psychologists, on the other hand, either abstained altogether from entering a domain in which they considered that mediocre work was being done, or focused on specific religious experiences, such as mysticism or ecstasy, (James 1958) as if they were paradigmatic of all forms of religiosity. (Lawson 2000).

During the last decades, there has been an attempt to reconcile the study of religion with the study of the mind, an attempt from which the interdisciplinary field of the Cognitive Study of Religion has emerged. The origins of this field can be found in the emergence of Cognitive Science, which was proposed in the 1950s as the new paradigm for the study of mental processing and gradually replaced the previously dominant behaviorist paradigm (Skinner 1938). The “cognitive revolution” began from research in Artificial Intelligence (Turing 1950; McCarthy et al. 1962, 1969; Minsky 1954; Newell et al. 1958, 1972; Simon 1969) and the study of memory (Miller 1956; Broadbent 1958).

In the study of culture, the most influential player was linguist Noam Chomsky (1957), who argued for a shift of focus, “from behavior and its products to the system of knowledge that enters into behavior” (1986: 28). By showing that important aspects of language acquisition are the product of universal capacities of the human brain, he delivered the final blow to Skinner’s radical behaviourism, which saw language as a learned habit (1959). Chomsky argued for the existence of an innate human linguistic capacity, a “universal grammar” that underlies every language’s particular grammar. He went on to propose his famous theory of transformational-generative grammar to model the innate knowledge that underlies the human ability to speak and understand language. For Chomsky, then, linguistics is ultimately a

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psychological pursuit, aiming to specify the biologically based principles of the mind that constrain the form of all natural languages. Soon thereafter, growing attention began to be directed to studies that focused on underlying commonalities rather than on surface variability of human traits and searched for a “universal grammar” underlying the particular semantics of cultural phenomena. (Berlin and Kay 1969; Hays 1983; Brown 1984; Atran 1990)

The first calls for a cognitive study of religious behavior appeared in the 1970's, (Lawson 1976; Staal 1979a, 1979b) and Dan Sperber's seminal book on symbolism (1975) was the work that had the greatest impact. Sperber criticized the existing semiotic approaches to symbolism and the dominant structuralist anthropological approach of his time, and proposed that symbolism is best understood not as a system of abstract signs and their meanings with its own rules, but rather as part of our normal mental processes of reasoning about the world. In 1996, he stressed the role of the cognitive constraints that bias the distribution of cultural representations, and shortly thereafter drew an analogy between the spreading of ideas and the spreading of viruses in populations. He proposed an “epidemiological approach” to cultural phenomena, which provides a framework to explore how certain ideas are selected for transmission while others simply fade away (1996). Opposing Richard Dawkins' theory of transmission of cultural representations as memes (Dawkins 1976), Sperber maintained that representations get transmitted not through precise replication, but through a process of constant transformation and re-representation.

The aim of the study of culture is to explain which psychological dispositions underlie the formation and distribution of representations and under which circumstances a relative stabilization of form or content occurs in the process of their generation. Representations move, as they are continuously transformed, towards attractors around which transformation tends to be limited and relative stability occurs. These attractors can be cross-cultural and panhuman or

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culture-specific and unsteady. The selective stabilization brought about by these attractors is the main force driving cultural evolution.

Towards the end of the twentieth century, cognitive scientists turned to investigate religious phenomena. Some of the scholars that established the field were Stewart Guthrie, with his work on anthropomorphism (1980 1993); Pascal Boyer, with his work on the naturalness of religious concepts (1994); David Lewis-Williams (1981), Merlin Donald, (1991) Steven Mithen (1996) and Terrence Deacon (1997), with their theories regarding the evolution of the human mind, symbolic representations, and the origins of religion; E. Thomas Lawson and Robert McCauley (Lawson and McCauley 1990; McCauley and Lawson 2002), with their Ritual Form Hypothesis on the relationship between ritual structure and people's intuitions about the efficacy of a ritual; and Harvey Whitehouse (1992, 1995, 2004), with the Modes Theory on the role of memory in religious transmission. On the basis of the pioneering work of these scholars, a plethora of publications appeared in the cognitive study of religion at the dawn of the new millennium.

The proponents of this paradigm argue that despite contextual differences, the seemingly boundless variability of cultural forms and expressions recorded by comparative scholars or religion is subject to panhuman constraints. The properties of the human brain (e.g. memory, theory of mind), the interaction between individuals and that between groups as manifested in historical forms and developments (e.g. political changes, wars, etc.), as well as the physical world in which we live and its particular geographies (e.g. available sources of food, geographic isolation), actively shape and constrain human expression and behavior (Whitehouse 2004). Religion is no exception; religious behavior is shaped by the same universal mental capacities of the human brain, while the representation of religious actions draws on the same panhuman cognitive mechanisms used for the representation of any kind of action.

3.5 Gathering Religious Data

For researchers of religion who wish to use quantitative data for the first time there are a number of issues to consider. Firstly, one needs to be aware of the sources of quantitative data. While most of the examples mentioned here are based on large scale national surveys, there are a number of other sources of quantitative data on religion, such as administrative records (e.g. church records) and commercial statistics (e.g. book sales). It is also possible to obtain data through the coding of qualitative data, such as media time / counts, textual content analysis and spatial analysis. Some data such as church records or large scale surveys are obtainable as *secondary data*, whereas others you can collect yourself, either by administering a questionnaire, or by counting (e.g. number of people who enter a mosque on a Friday, the number of times “God” is mentioned in a radio show etc.).

Data collected by the researcher is called “primary data”. The advantage of primary data gathering is that you can tailor-make your own survey questions, research site and sampling to suit your particular research questions. The downside is that it is often time consuming and potentially expensive. It may also be difficult to achieve a sample that is sufficiently large or representative. In contrast, with secondary quantitative analysis, the data is immediately available, and often of high quality. National government-funded surveys typically have large random samples and cost millions of pounds to produce. However, if using one of these surveys one only has answers to the questions asked and so it is important to make sure that the information suitable to answer your research question is available before picking a secondary data source.

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It is also important to differentiate between *aggregate statistics*, such as numbers in tabular form or opinion polls that are based on analysis by other people, and *microdata*, that is the raw data records giving items of information (variables) for each individual (cases).

Webpages such as BRIN and ARDA are excellent sources for the former, but to produce your own charts and tables you need the original microdata. The Economic and Social Data service (ESDS) is a good source for British survey data, and their website has a search tool for variables, where you can enter your topic of interest and see which surveys have covered it. This could also be useful if you are planning to collect or if you have collected your own data and you want to compare any of the questions and distributions with those of a representative survey.

3.6 Indicators Of Religious Behavior

Several indicators of religious behavior has been identified over time:

- Subjective religiosity
- Attending religious services
- Praying
- Belief

The three components of religiosity with which we began are familiar to social psychologists who generally recognize the importance of making a distinction between knowing (cognition), feeling (affect), and doing (behavior). This distinction is not new to the study of religiosity. Hall (1891), Starbuck (1899), and Leuba (1912) made early distinctions between religious belief, religious feelings, and religious works or practices.

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The cognitive component is the religious belief or orthodoxy component. Glock (1962) called this dimension “ideology,” Stark and Glock (1968) later labeled it “orthodoxy,” and King and Hunt (1975) called it “creedal assent.”

The affective component is the feeling dimension and encompasses feelings toward religious beings, objects, or institutions. The term religious commitment has been used rather loosely in the literature, but our use of the term to label the affective component is not entirely inconsistent with the work of Becker (1960), Selznick (1949), and Kanter (1968). The problem with these definitions is that they emphasize only the behavioral aspect of commitment at the expense of understanding the affective component. More consistent with our approach is that of Hans Mol (1977) who argues that commitment is an important mechanism for maintaining a religious identity and defines it as “focused emotion or emotional attachment to a specific focus of identity” (1977, p. 216).

The behavioral component is “acted out.” Church attendance, financial contributions, frequency of personal prayer and scripture study, and religious and ethical behaviors are all included in the behavioral component of religiosity.

Religiosity also consists of two *modes* of religious involvement: the personal mode and the institutional mode. The literature on religiosity is replete with such a distinction. Dittes (1971) made a distinction between religion in a relatively explicit mode—public, social, institutionalized, and formalized—and religion in the more subjective mode—deeply held personal attitudes, values, loyalties, and commitments.

Sociologists have frequently made a distinction between these two modes of religiosity with concepts like “meaning and belonging” (Greeley 1972; Roof 1979), “private and public”

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(Davidson 1975, 1977), or “moral and calculative” (Etzioni 1961), and “religious group involvement” vs. “religious orientations” (Lanski 1961).

The personal mode is comprised of religious beliefs, feelings, and behaviors that find their source in personal and individualized religion. This includes the acceptance of doctrinal orthodoxy drawn from a broader cultural milieu (i.e., general Christianity as opposed to doctrines of a particular sect or denomination), feelings and commitment toward God, and religious behavior (personal prayer, giving to the poor, and encouraging others to believe in Christ).

The institutional mode is comprised of the religious beliefs, feelings, or behaviors related to formalized and institutionalized religion. The institutional mode includes acceptance of religious beliefs which are unique to a sect or denomination, personal feelings and attachments to a particular church or congregation, and participation in religious ritual and worship services.

A cross-classification of these two constructs: (1) the modes of religiosity (personal vs. institutional) and (2) the components of religiosity (belief, commitment, and behavior) provides a classification scheme for identifying six distinct dimensions of religiosity: traditional and particularistic orthodoxy (cognitive), spiritual and church commitment (affective), and religious behavior and participation (behavioral). Within each mode there exists a sequential interaction among the three components. That is, in order to be committed to God, one must believe in Him, and commitment to God influences religious behavior. On the other hand, in order to feel committed to a church or organization, one must believe it to be a good and viable organization, and commitment to the organization influences participation and acceptance of the behavioral norms and expectations of the organization.

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3.7 Note



The scientific study of religion is done for purely intellectual/scientific reasons and not as an instrument in the achievement of religious, cultural or political ends.

3.8 Questions



- Analyze the advantages of studying religion as a science.
- “During the second half of the 20th century, there has been an attempt to reconcile the study of religion with the study of the mind” comment.

3.9 Activity



Find out how church attendance, financial contributions, personal prayer and bible reading are included in the behavioral component of religiosity.

3.10 Further reading



Jeremiah M. Nyaudi, *Introduction to the Study of Religion: A Study of the Phenomenon of Religion*. (Eldoret: Zapf Chancery Publishers, 2004).

Ninian Smart, *The Phenomenon of Religion*. (New York: Seabury, 1973).

4. CONTEMPORARY TRENDS IN SCIENTIFIC STUDY OF RELIGION

4.1 Objectives



By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Fully grasp the methodology of the scientific study of religion.
- Identify the contributions of various scholars in the process.

4.2 Methodology Of Scientific Study Of Religion

The scientific study of religion represents the systematic effort by scholars and researchers to investigate religious phenomena, as well as the sociology of church participation.

The society for the Scientific Study of religion was founded in 1949 by scholars in religion and social science, and it publishes the *Journal for the study of religion*, a quarterly which “offers perspectives on national and international issues such as brainwashing and cults, religious persecution, and right with authoritarianism”

The Center for the Scientific Study of Religion (CSSR) at the University of Texas at Austin is a leading center for the sociology of religion, and particularly for the study of religious influences on human behavior and population outcomes.

4.3 Max Muller

Religious studies originated in the nineteenth century, when scholarly and historical analysis of the Bible had flourished, and Hindu and Buddhist texts were first being translated into

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European languages. Early influential scholars included Friedrich Max Muller, in England, and Cornelius P. Tiele, in the Netherlands. Today religious studies is practiced by scholars worldwide. In its early years, it was known as Comparative Religion or the Science of Religion and, in USA, there are those who today also know the field as the History of religion (associated with methodological traditions traced to the University of Chicago in general, and in particular Mircea Eliade, from the late 1950s through to the late 1980s). The field is also known as *Religionwissenschaft* in Germany and *Sciences des religions* in the French-speaking world.

The term “religion” originated from the Latin noun “religio”, that was nominalized from one of three verbs: “relegere” (to turn constantly/observe conscientiously); “religare” (to bind oneself [back]); and “reeligere” (to choose again). Because of these three different meanings, any etymological analysis alone does not resolve the ambiguity of defining religion, since each verb points to a different understanding of what religion is. During the Medieval period, the term “religious” was used as a noun to describe someone who had joined a monastic order (a “religious”). Despite this change in meaning, it is important to note the term “religion” is primarily a Christian term. Judaism and Hinduism, for example, do not include this term in their vocabulary.

4.4 Ninian Smart

In the 1960s and 1970s, the term “religious studies” became common and interest in the field increased. New departments were founded and influential journals of religious studies were initiated (for example, *Religious studies and Religion*). In the forward to *Approaches to the Study of Religion*, Ninian Smart wrote that “in the English-speaking world [religious studies]

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basically dates from the 1960s, although before then there were such fields as ‘the comparative study of religion’, the ‘history of religion’, ‘sociology of religion’ and so on...”

In the 1980s, in both Britain and America, “the decrease in student applications and diminishing resources in the 1980s led to cut backs affecting religious studies departments.”

(Partridge) Later in the decade, religious studies began to pick up as a result of integrating religious studies with other disciplines and forming programs of study that mixed the discipline with more utilitarian study.

Philosophy of religion uses philosophical tools to evaluate religious claims and doctrines. Western philosophy has traditionally been employed by English speaking scholars. (Some other cultures have their own philosophical traditions including Indian, Muslim, and Jewish). Common issues considered by the (Western) philosophy of religion are the existence of God, belief and rationality, cosmology, and logical inferences of logical consistency from sacred texts.

4.5 Edmund Husserl

Husserl grew up in a Jewish family that accepted Christian baptism when Edmund was 27; some of his writings show interest in religion but as a philosopher he referred little to Biblical religion. An autonomous philosophy, as the Aristotelian was and as it remains an eternal demand, comes necessarily to a teleology and philosophical theology—as a way to God bound up with no particular religion. One of the research manuscripts characterizes this God of the philosopher. God as idea, as the idea of the most perfect being, as the idea of the most perfect life, which out of itself constitutes the most perfect “world,” which out of itself creatively

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develops the most perfect world of spirits in relation to a most perfect nature. Husserl went ahead to describe “places” for religious experience.

Religious experience weaves (1) experiences of supreme truth, beauty, and goodness, and (2) orientations to the religious other that prepare, are fulfilled in, and transcend such experiences. He mentioned truth, beauty, and goodness together since whichever one predominates is implicitly accompanied by the other two. Experiences of supreme value can lead to worship, and still deeper motivations can conduct the experience. There are cathedrals in Spain that preserve the medieval gates separating the priest from the rest of the people; the priest performs the mass with his back to them; perhaps they do not hear or do not understand what he says; they sense something sacred transpiring and allow it to continue. The intellect’s limits in comprehending worship are expressed in metaphors of darkness or “the cloud of unknowing.” Something of the worship experience registers in consciousness, and as awareness returns to normal, one has the sense that something profoundly wonderful has transpired, but one does not altogether know what.

The concept of an indwelling divine spirit, the presence of God within the mind, is widespread, and may become a focus in religious experience. Many people report an inner source of energy, wisdom, insight, love, peace, creativity, guidance, or purpose. They may come to such experiences by following the instruction simply to *consent* to the presence and activity of the indwelling spirit. Upon finding oneself distracted, one returns gently in receptivity to the focus, either by using the name of one’s choice or by returning without using any name at all.

Husserl expresses the conviction that God is active in human beings generally. God’s might lives and realizes itself nowhere else than in us, in our radically authentic will. Where else does he, the living God, work than in our life, in our pure will? He works in the deepest roots of the

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authentic person who does not will anything but what is true, as that which we cannot let go of without being forced to give up our life as meaningless. (Hua XXVII, 122)

Here we see a matrix of associations linking God, love, will, and the deepest roots of the authentic person. In addition, Husserl refers to God as “the unsearchable within” and remarks that prayerful intentionality directs itself “within” to “the inkling of the interiority (*Innensein*) of God which founds every real relating.” Hart expands the point.

4.6 Note



The scientific study of religion was developed in the 20th Century.

4.7 Questions



Discuss the contributions of two of the following scholars in the scientific study of religion:

- (a.) Max Muller
- (b.) Ninian Smart
- (c.) Edmund Husserl

4.8 Activity



Open the internet and read a few editions of the Journal For The Study of Religion.

4.9 Further reading



Jeremiah M. Nyaudi, *Introduction to the Study of Religion: A Study of the Phenomenon of Religion*. (Eldoret: Zapf Chancery Publishers, 2004).

Ninian Smart. *The Phenomenon of Religion*. (New York: Seabury, 1973).

5. THEORIES THAT HAVE SHAPED THE CURRENT UNDERSTANDING AND INTERPRETATION OF RELIGION

5.1 Objectives



By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Distinguish and understand the six theories that shaped and influenced the current trends in the study of religion

5.2 Sociological Theories

Sociological theories of religion help us to analyze the relationship between the society and religion and give us the insight into the role that religion plays in people's lives. They do not seek to verify or disclaim individual faiths or to make value judgments about religious beliefs.

A few of the important theories include:

5.2.1 Emile Durkheim

Emile Durkheim (1858-1917) was the pioneer in the sociology of religion. In 1912 this French

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Sociologist, published a very important work entitled *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life*, in which he tried to identify the origin and the elements common to all religions. Durkheim argues that religion originated in the gathering of the totemic clan. Ordinarily, the members of the clan lived apart. Whenever they gathered, their sheer contact with one another created an extra-ordinary feeling of energy and power. They felt infused, uplifted, and powerful. Knowing that individually they lacked this power, they ascribed it not to themselves but to something external. They attributed it to the totemic emblem and they took it as the object of worship. Since the supernatural power that they ascribed to the totemic emblem was in fact their own collective power, the true origin of religion was their own mutual experience of themselves among themselves.

Through his survey of religions, Durkheim seems to hold that there is no identical belief or practice. However he did find that all religions, regardless of their name or teaching, separate the sacred from the profane. By sacred, Durkheim referred to those aspects of life, which inspire awe, reverence, deep respect, and even fear. By profane, he meant those aspects of life that were not concerned with religion or religious purposes but were parts of the ordinary aspects of worldly life. He also found that all religions develop a community around their practices and beliefs. Thus according to Durkheim, a religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices related to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden, which unite into one single moral community called a church, and all those who adhere to them. Throughout human history, the distinction between the profane and the sacred has been central to all religions. In brief, religion is a system of beliefs and practices acknowledging the Sacred. Since religion deals with ideas that transcend experiences, neither sense nor science can establish religious truths. Religion is a matter of faith, matters of faith vary greatly. It all depends on how we interpret it.

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According to Durkheim we understand profane things in terms of their utility. What is defined as sacred, however, is separated from everyday life and denotes as "set apart and forbidden", so that it evokes a reverence. Emile Durkheim recognized that it is the society, not the individual that distinguishes between sacred and profane things. There is nothing in an object that makes it intrinsically sacred. And this sacred is attributed or imparted through rituals and *so* accepted by the society.

5.2.2 Karl Marx

Half a century before Durkheim, Karl Marx also portrayed religion as a reflection of society. When Durkheim emphasized the positive functions of religion, Marx stressed its dysfunctions. According to him, all religions reflect the fact that human lives are controlled by external powers over which they have no control. They are influenced by the external forces that control their daily life, where the terrestrial forces assume the form of supernatural forces. Marx made a contrast between primitive religions and modern religions. According to him it was the power of nature that controlled man in the primitive society, whereas in the modern world it is the forces of social system, which exercise this external dominance.

‘In the beginning of history it was the forces of nature which were first *so* reflected and which in the course of further evolution underwent the most manifold and varied personifications among the various people....But it is not long before, side by side with the forces of nature, social forces begin to be active - forces which confront man as equally alien and at first equally inexplicable, dominating him with the same apparent natural necessity as the forces of nature themselves. The fantastic figures, which at first

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only reflected the mysterious forces of nature, at this point acquire social attributes, become representatives of the forces of history’.

According to Marx, man projects his own perfection into the supernatural and calls the sum of these qualities as 'God', and thus he is alienated. It is the economic and social forces that drive human beings to create this illusion of God. Man needs to be emancipated from the underlying causes of alienation found in the economic order. For, "it is not the consciousness of men that determines their beings, but on the contrary, their social being that determines their consciousness. Accordingly, Marx sees the criticism of religion only as a preliminary step to the criticism of society, and criticism of society goes hand in hand with the revolutionary political action, which not only changes society but also destroys the basis of religion.

The fundamental principle of Marx's critique of religion is that man makes religion and religion does not make man. Religion is described as the 'moral sanction', the 'solemn completion', and the 'universal ground for consolation and justification' for this world. Hence, according to Marx, religion has become an integral part of this distorted world. So much so, religion has become necessary for the consolation of human beings in this world. Therefore Marx says: "Religious distress is at the same time the expression of real distress and protest against real distress. Religion is the sigh of the oppressed creature, the heart of a heartless world, just as it is the spirit of a spiritless situation. It is the opium of the people.

It is a complete distortion if this oft-quoted passage is taken as some sort of atheism or as rejection of religion, it becomes a distortion of this theory. Here religion is described as the expression of this world's distress, as the "sigh of the oppressed creature. However, at the same time religion is also a protest against this distress. But such protest, according to Marx, remains vain and ineffective because it diverts attention from this world and focuses hope on the next.

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By diverting their eyes to future happiness in a coming world, religion takes their eyes off from their sufferings in this world, thereby greatly reducing the possibility of rebelling against their oppressors. When Durkheim saw religion as beneficial to all segments of society by promoting social commitment, Marx held the view that religion serves the interests of the ruling elite at the expense of the masses.

Any theory can be understood in its essence when we understand the concrete situation in which it originated. The crucial point and the very essence of Marx's critique of religion are not its denial of God, but the affirmation and acknowledgment of human autonomy. He wanted to overthrow all relations in which man is debased, enslaved and abandoned.

5.2.3 Max Weber (1864 - 1920)

Karl Marx inspired Max Weber's interest in religion to some degree. Like Marx, Weber devoted much of his intellectual life to investigating the history of capitalism. He credited Marx for highlighting the role of economics in history. But Marx believed that all history could be explained as class struggle on the basis of economics, while Weber argued economics as only one of the many factors influencing the course of history. Marx held the view that religion is an obstacle to social change, whereas Weber argued that religion could also be an agent of social change. In his book *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, Max Weber holds that the Protestant belief was one of the many factors that contributed to the rise of capitalism.

Although he disagreed with Marx's economic determinism, he did not disprove the role of economics in history. The aim of this book was to show that history could not be reduced to one-factor explanations and that religion could be an agent of social change. From the above perspective, religion could be understood and interpreted as instrumental to reveal human problems and also to find solutions from the sociological perspective. The Sociologists

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recognize that religion is central to every culture and they seek to understand how religious beliefs and practices guide human societies. Whatever be their personal religious beliefs, sociologists agree that religion is a major social institution that must be understood in the context of the society. According to them religion promotes social cohesion by uniting members of a society through shared symbols, values and norms.

5.3 Psychological Theories

Religion is not a major area of interest in psychology. Many textbooks of psychology do not devote much attention to religious issues. In some cases, the attitude is one of suspicion and even of hostility. Nevertheless, the contribution of many psychologists about religion and its role in human life cannot be ignored. Some of them are indeed very important and worth studying. Most psychological theories emphasize emotional aspects of religion. The main proponents of these theories are William James, Sigmund Freud, Carl Jung, Gordon Allport, Abraham Maslow, Alfred Adler, Erik Erikson etc. The following are some of the salient features of their theories.

5.3.1 William James (1842 - 1910)

His book *The Varieties of Religious Experience: A Study in Human Nature* (1902) is considered by many to be the classic work in the field, not only because it was one of the first studies on religious experience by a psychologist, but also because of his approach. This book provided an early impetus for the psychology of religion. According to him there is possibility of both a healthy as well as sick form of religion. He thinks that there is something in human consciousness different from particular sensations. He distinguished between institutional religion and personal religion. Institutional religion refers to the religious group or organization,

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which plays an important part in a society's culture. Personal religion, in which the individual has a mystical experience, can be experienced regardless of the culture. He was mainly interested in understanding personal religious experiences. Religious consciousness originates in the individual through a mystical experience. It can be transmitted and developed with the help of worship, prayer, meditation and the like with the help of institutional religion. **5.3.2**

Sigmund Freud (1856 - 1939)

Freud's critique of religion is well known to academic community. It is important to understand his position correctly, since it is often misunderstood. He laid the foundation of psychoanalysis and he has tremendous influence on modern society. Our understanding about the unconscious mind, childhood, parenthood etc. comes mainly from the Freudian literature. In his writings, he tries to explain how we are influenced by the past events and by things outside our conscious mind. According to Freud, people experience conflicts between what they desire to do (represented by our Id) and the social control over our desires (represented by the Superego). These conflicts are resolved, to a greater or lesser degree, by the Ego. Freud thinks that religion springs from the unresolved Oedipus complex - the boy's sexual love for the mother and simultaneous fear and hate for the father. As a result, in the unconscious realm of the boy's mind 'the feared father becomes the feared God'. It is the guilt feeling of the people who cannot accept their desires and hatred that lead them to postulate and to fear a god. Freud viewed religion as originating in the child's relationship to the father; hence in many cultures *God* is viewed as a Heavenly Father. In this way, religion reflects the attempt to fulfil our wishes, and thus it remains an illusion.

According to Freud, the faith in God and religion need not always be wrong. If at all it is illusory, all illusions need not always be false. He thinks that religious doctrines can be illusions, because there is no proof for them and that they seem to contradict our scientific knowledge.

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Further, it is felt that their authenticity cannot be proved. Freud's approach to religion is called "ontogenetic theory of religion", which refers to the development of the individual. Regarding the origin of religion in the society, he accepted the patricide theory of some anthropologists, without proving or disproving it (how the sons kill their tyrannical father and later, obsessed by regret, worship him). This is what he termed as the 'phylogenetic theory of religion', which speaks about the racial development. Freud does not subscribe to atheism, nor disprove the teachings of religion. He does not even say that religious ideas are along. He called them illusions because he believed that they were the fruits of human wishes rather than of rational inquiry. He considered religious practices as neurotic. He saw religious ritual as something similar to the obsessional neurotic behavior of patients (who did things for no apparent reason). Freud often describes the religious beliefs and practices as expressions of illusions and neurosis. Freud's views on religion seem to have considerably influenced our society.

According to Freud, religion tries to fulfil our wishes and thus it remains as an illusion. The desire for security and companionship is fulfilled through religion. He attributed undue importance to sexuality over spirituality in one's psychological development. As Freud was a product of modernism, which was mainly influenced by scientism, his approach was not holistic to the reality. The modernists believed that reality is only materialistic and physical and consequently many of them believed in scientism and rejected the metaphysical realities. Scientism shows that the methods used in studying natural sciences could be employed in investigating all the aspects of human behavior, philosophy and reality in general. This does not appear to be tenable, precisely because reality cannot be restricted to the physical realm alone. One must keep in mind that absence of knowledge about certain realities should not be equated with the knowledge of their absence. In other words, because we do not know certain

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realities, it does not necessarily mean that they do not exist. Hence it will not be true/proper for a scientist to deny the metaphysical and supernatural realities, just because they are not known to him.

5.3.3 Alfred Adler (1870 - 1937)

He was an Austrian psychiatrist who parted ways with Freud. Adler emphasized the role of goals and motivation in his famous book *Individual Psychology*. One of his most famous ideas is that we try to compensate for our inferiorities through religion. Lack of power often lies at the root of an inferiority feeling. Our belief in God shows our tendency to strive for perfection and superiority. In many religions, God is considered to be perfect and omnipotent, and desires His people to be perfect. If we want to achieve perfection, we must satisfy His desires.

Much of Adler's writing is devoted to social movements. He is interested mostly in the idea of God as a motivator, and not in the question of whether or not God exists. What is important is that God (or the idea of God) motivates people to act, and that those actions do have real impact upon us and on others. Our view of God is important because it activates and controls our actions. Religion is important because it exerts great influence on the social aspect of our life, and is important as a powerful social movement itself. Compared to science, religion is more powerful because it motivates people more effectively. According to Adler, religion seems to play a dominant role in motivating people with better vision, mission and action. This appears to be true, as the sensitivity of religion has grown so high to the extent of religious fanaticism and fundamentalism. What we require is a balanced outlook and equanimity in religious matters.

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5.3.4 Carl Gustav Jung (1875 - 1961)

Although a follower of Freud in the beginning, Jung left the Freudian school of thought when Freud attributed undue importance to sexuality over spirituality. Jung was concerned with the interplay between conscious and unconscious forces. He proposed two kinds of unconsciousness; namely personal and collective. Personal unconscious includes those things about ourselves that we would like to forget. The collective unconscious refers to events that we all share, by virtue of having a common heritage, belonging to human species. He was fascinated by non-western views, and sought to find some common ground between East and West.

Jung is well known for his study of archetypes and the impact of religion on the individual's life. Jung does not seem to be interested in arguing out or in rejecting the truth-claims of religious doctrines. What matters for him is the psychological impact of the religious belief in a person's life. According to him nobody knows the ultimate reality. We must, therefore, accept it as we experience them. And if such an experience helps to make one's life better, more beautiful, more perfect and more satisfactory to oneself and to others, one may consider it as grace of God. He gave much importance to the experience of the individual. He viewed religion positively and according to him religion helps people to resolve their inner conflicts and attain maturity. For Jung religion is more an instrument or medium for the transformation of the personal I&. Hence for him, religion is more ethical than dogmatic and ritualistic.

5.3.5 Gordon Allport (1897 - 1967)

In his classic book, *'The Individual and His Religion- A Psychological Interpretation'*, Allport illustrates how people may use religion in different ways. He makes a distinction between mature and immature religions. Mature religion promotes dynamism, open mindedness, and

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altruism in contrast, immature religion is self serving, closed and unkind. Allport looked at the positive and negative impact of religion on its followers. Positively they are forgiving, generous, kind, humble, open etc. Negatively, people are cruel, intolerant, narrow-minded selfrighteous and the' like. Hence, there are different types of people in religion. Those who take it seriously see in it a motivational source and perform well; the doubters see it as a sign of immaturity and weakness. As a psychologist, Allport is more interested in the psychological aspect of religion than in its truth claims.

Allport is neither against religion nor for religion. He held that the search for an adequate belief system must go on. Yet, 'as a science, psychology can neither prove nor disprove religion's claims to truth. It can, however, help explain why these claims are so many and so diverse... The final truths of religion are unknown, but a psychology that impedes the understanding of religious potentialities of man scarcely deserves to be called the logos of the human psyche at all'. Regarding the origins of religion, Allport believed that there could be numerous interpretations and no uniformity could be expected. According to him religion can be helpful or detrimental to man's integral growth. It influences his life. He does not approve of all things manifested as religiosity.

5.3.6 Abraham Maslow (1908 - 1970)

According to Maslow religion provides people with a transcendental understanding of the world. What makes someone psychologically healthy' was the question that guided Maslow's work. To this end, he developed a hierarchy of needs, ranging from lower level physiological needs, through love and belonging, to self actualization. Self-actualized people are those who have reached their potential for self-development. From being a militant atheist, Maslow became more and more attuned to the mystical dimension of life. Maslow claimed that

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mystics are more likely to be self-actualized than other people. Mystics also are more likely to have had "peak experiences", experiences in which the person feels a sense of ecstasy and oneness with the universe. Although his hierarchy of needs sounds appealing, many find it difficult to support his theory. Nevertheless, his work led to research on religion, peak experiences and the links between self-actualization and piety. The self actualization theory of Maslow was more in the line of the personality development in its fullest expression. But when we come to the fag end of this thought development, he seems to identify the religious experience and self actualization which leads to the transformation of the self.

5.3.7 Erik H. Erikson (1902 - 1994)

Though Erikson's direct or central interest is not religion, his study on Luther reveals a stand quite different from Freud's. Unlike Freud, Erikson takes Luther's stand seriously. He believes that religion need not be regression; instead it can promote creativity. Religious counsellors and spiritual guides have extensively used Erikson's theory of life stages. From his study of life stages and of Luther and of Mahatma Gandhi, Erikson comes to the conclusion that is very different from that of Freud. Religion, according to him can be distorted to pathological uses, or be a vital force for maturity and social support. Religion helps the person to have a fuller development at different: stages. He believes that psychologically, religion is a good medium for the transformation of the person.

5.3.8 Erich Fromm

According to Erich Fromm the important thing is to express all the love that we are capable of. The mentally healthy person is the one who lives his life by love, reason, and faith.⁴⁶ Even when he speaks of the love of God, Fromm says that he does not mean this in a theistic sense, but rather as an ultimate concern. According to him there exists no spiritual realm outside man

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or transcending him. Erich Fromm holds a healthy idea of religion, which has to be lived in love, reason and faith. For him, the very creation and all beings are manifestations of God himself.

When religion, mankind's oldest and probably the deepest concern, is willing to face the challenges and insights of one of the most influential academic fields today, the results expected can be rich and controversial, deep and provocative. When Psychology and religion meet, there is always an understandable excitement in the air, since both fields touch us at our deepest core. Serious research shows that neither field has anything to fear from the other, but only from misconstructions of each other's nature and; purpose. All psychological theories of religion agree on one thing: whatever be its origins or purpose, whatever be its beliefs or rituals, religion can serve to satisfy psychological needs common to all people.

All these theories point to the fact that man is religious by nature. This religious nature seeks its fulfilment in proper and peaceful relationships. If we understand religion as relation with oneself, with others and with the Divine, this becomes all the more true.

5.4 Anthropological Theories

Anthropology is the science of man, which deals specially with the beginning, development, customs, and beliefs of mankind. The earliest archaeological findings of religion are derived from Neanderthal burials. The fact that Neanderthals buried their dead and put objects in their graves point towards some kind of their belief in life after death. However, we do not have sufficient evidences and details of their religion. Nevertheless, there are several theories put forward on the origin of religions. Out of the many theories, a few of the important ones include:

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5.4.1 Animism

This is said to be the first theory on the origin of religions and is based on the study of the mind and habits of the savage. It first appeared in Edward Burnett Tylor's monumental volumes 'Primitive Culture' and he is said to be the founder of the anthropology of religion. According to Tylor, religion originated when people attempted to understand conditions and events that could not be explained by daily experiences. He believed that our ancestors were particularly intrigued with death, dreaming and trance. In his dreams, he dreamt that his body remained in one place and his self wandered about and did various things. Also in his dreams he saw other persons whose bodies were not in the places where they should have been. From this, he deduced that there must exist within himself two beings." The being that is active during the day, is the body; and the other, active during sleep and trance, is the soul. They are intimately related to each other. When the soul permanently leaves the body, the human being dies.

The Latin word for soul is *anima* and the theory coined from this belief is called 'animism'. According to the primitive man, death is a prolonged sleep in which the body disintegrates. From this he concluded that the soul become free from the bondages of the body and remained as disembodied spirit. These spirits are endowed with the capabilities of either helping or harming the human beings and other creatures. In order to conciliate and appease these spirits, there arose offerings, prayers, sacrifices and other religious rituals. Tylor thinks that religion evolved through the various stages of animism, pantheism, polytheism and finally to monotheism. According to him religion was invented to explain things people did not understand and thought that it would decline, as science would offer better explanations. It seems that to a certain extent this explanation is right, but it has not taken the other functions

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of religions into consideration. In brief, animism is the attribution of the soul to the natural objects and that the soul is the vital principle.

It is generally recognized that the animistic belief is universal at a certain phase of human culture and civilization. As a theory it is not sound and satisfactory, for it is not clear how the spirits animate the objects of nature. Further, we do not find a satisfactory explanation as to how they evoke religious sentiments and feelings. As it is not a treatise on philosophy of religion, we do not require going deeper into the subject. However, one cannot deny the fact it is a rudimentary form of religion and that they had some clear idea about the soul as a disembodied spirit, which could exist even after the disintegration of the body. This is indeed central to any religion of modern times and therefore animism could be considered as a form of religion.

5.4.2 Animatism

There is another theory regarding the origin of religion. The primitives saw the supernatural as a domain of impersonal power or force. It influenced them under certain conditions, and they believed that they could control it. This view of the supernatural is called animatism. This impersonal force that exists in the universe and could reside in people, animals, plants and objects was called '*mana*'. It is an all-pervading invisible power or influence that operates in unintelligible ways or appears in natural objects of striking character. It is similar to our notion of luck. People attributed success to the possession of *mana* which individuals could acquire in different ways and they believed that rulers and nobles had more *mana* than ordinary people. As per this theory, contact between the chief and the commoner was dangerous because *mana* could work like an electric shock. Ordinary people could not bear as much sacred current as royal people, and hence there arose rites to purify the exposed individuals out of necessity.

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Anthropological theories show that religious instinct is innate in man. It unites the different dimensions of his existence like body, soul, activities and the concept of life after death. These dimensions are common to religious people. Religion had its origin in the attempt of man to establish a relationship between him and certain spirits. The primitive man's instinctive tendencies were not simply left behind but rather sublimated as he became civilized. The primitive man still lives in all of us. This does not mean that there has been no development. There has been development as well as continuity. Anthropologists study religion as a behavioral pattern related to supernatural beings, which are personal spirits and impersonal forces.

5.5 Feminist Theories

Religion has been seen as a major institution for the social control of women. It has been the focus of feminist attacks in both first and second wave feminism. Elizabeth Cady Stanton's last work, *The Woman's Bible*, in 1895 (1972), and Mary Daly's first work, *The Church and the Second Sex* in 1975 (1985), were attacks on institutionalized religion and its treatment of women. Yet women have also found ways of using religious ideologies to argue for egalitarian treatment or demand that men change their behavior. Women have sometimes found space in religious institutions to organize on their own behalf; at other times they have created femalebased religious groups.

Feminists argue that in religion there is evidence of an oppression against women. They highlight 4 ways in which religion oppresses and subordinates women:

1. Sacred texts – sacred texts feature predominantly male gods and profits as well as being written and interpreted by men. Women in sacred texts are presented in a negative light.

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For example, Eve and Lot's daughters. However, this ignores positive descriptions of women in the sacred texts such as the Virgin Mary.

2. Places of worship – there are often rules that only pertain to women that prevent women from participating fully. For example, not being able to touch holy books when on menses or not being able to speak in the religious place. Women are often segregated and marginalized (poor seating). Holm refers to this as the devaluation of women in contemporary religion.
3. Religious laws and customs – they can end up giving women less rights than men and influence the way in which a nation is run. Many religions legitimate and regulate women's traditional and domestic role.
4. Religious organizations – many are male dominated and prevent women from being in positions of leadership despite women having a higher attendance than men in religion.

Armstrong refers to this as the marginalization of women.

However, religion has not always been like this as there was a time when religion was very woman centered, e.g. mother goddesses, fertility cults and women priesthoods. It was the rise of male dominated, monotheistic religions such as Christianity, Islam and Judaism that led to the oppression of women in religion. According to El Saadawi, it was the interpretation of religion in a male dominated patriarchal society that led to male domination in religion – not religion itself.

Like El Saadawi, there is Woodhead that argues religion is not oppressive to women. She argues that women can use religion to liberate themselves and to feel more valued. E.g. in the Evangelical Church, the combination of the saying “you should practice what you preach” & “husbands should love their wives as Christ loved the Church” can be used by women to prevent

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abuse by their husbands. In Islam, women wearing the headscarf gives them ability to have jobs and experience the world without losing their identity, thus liberating them from the housewife role.

Other criticisms

- Marxists would argue the working class are truly oppressed by religion – not women.
- Functionalists would argue that is not oppressive but is helping women to know their gender role, thus creating social cohesion.
- New Age religions such as crystal healing and feng shui are dominated by women so are not oppressive. But are New Age practices religions?

Even if religions were oppressive, Leymah Gbowee shows how women can overcome that and use religion for their own liberation.

5.6 Theological Theories

The Italian theologian, P. Rosario, traces the origin of religion to human nature itself, which according to him has a religious dimension. The human spirit is constantly and continuously searching for its source, i.e., the intimate spirit. This search of the finite spirit for the infinite spirit its source is what constitutes religion. This can be traced to the submission of St Augustine as the restlessness of the human spirit for its source; the infinite spirit or, in other words, God. That is why man experiences uneasiness, dissatisfaction and insecurity. He experience an emptiness or a vacuum within him and nothing finite can satisfy his most basic desire which he often does not quite understanding himself.

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5.7 Philosophical Theories

For anyone to subscribe to a religion, then it must be accepted that such a person is also accepting certain purely philosophical doctrines. For example, if you believe in a non-material God, then you believe that not all that exists is material, and that means you accept a metaphysics of immaterialism. If you believe that you should love your neighbor because God said you should, then you are taking sides in the debate among ethical philosophers. You have committed yourself to a stand against naturalism. These and many other metaphysical, ethical and epistemological points of view and principles are assumed by, and incorporated in religion, and it is the business of the philosophy of religion to understand and rationally evaluate them. So naturally, the philosophy of religion is not only necessary, but the end product of human quest for knowledge.

The Enlightenment helped to shape the philosophical and intellectual climate of the eighteenth-century. This intellectual movement made conscious and deliberate break with the past and ushered in the so called modern period by taking a fresh look at reality and presenting a different view of the natural world, of human nature, of society and of religion. A feature of the enlightenment was the conviction that the past, especially the Middle Ages, had been dark and that the eighteenth-century signaled the dawn of a new age, variously known as the age of Enlightenment, the age of reason, the *Aufklärung* (German) and the *Siecle des Lumiers* (French). There was a sense of humanity emerging from darkness to new light, because now human being could rely on reason and see what their predecessors could not see clearly. In consequence, men of the enlightenment raised questions about humanity and its destiny, about the origin and character of religion, about the source of state authority. In the process, they called into question long-cherished beliefs and various social sanctions. In short, the principles

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of criticism applied by the thinkers of the enlightenment struck at the very foundation of organized religion and government.

Initially, enlightenment was not antireligious, despite its insistence on the principle of criticism and on freedom of faith and conscience which led it to assign to reason the noble task of being “our last judge of and guide in everything” – even in matters of religion.

Before long, the Bible began to lose its authority and credibility as it became clear that certain Biblical accounts, such as the creation stories, could not stand the test of reason, especially after the discoveries of Copernicus, Galileo and Newton had convincingly demonstrated that the earth was not the center of the universe but revolves around the sun. Thus, was born the greatest attack to religion in the Western society. But through the ages, scholars have also come up with various theories in defense of religion but this cannot be done without first understanding the basis, technique and areas of departure that existed between philosophy and religion. Hence, the discipline of philosophy of religion was given birth to.

In the past, the practitioners of the discipline of philosophy have often viciously attacked religion and all it entails and thereby discarding it as mere superstition. This is because these philosophers were insensitive to religion. Some of them even assert that the term philosophy of religion is unintelligible. This is why the likes of Lord Mosley have argued that those that must engage in philosophy of religion must at least have an idea of what religion is all about. Philosophy of religion centers largely on the metaphysical, ethical and epistemological beliefs of religion that philosophers have sought to understand and evaluate. Many of these beliefs have to do with God. GOD: that he exists, that he is good, that he created the universe and is the source of all that is real, that he is a personal deity; that he is the transcendent deity, and so forth.

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Many also have to do with HUMANS: that human were created in the image of God, that they have free will, that they can have knowledge of God's will, that the human soul is immortal, and so on. Other beliefs have to do with the universe. For example, that there are miracles; that there is supernatural reality, that there is pain and suffering (a fact thought to require reconciliation with the belief in a good and all powerful God). And still others have to do with language. That religious language is intelligible and meaningful; that religious utterance are (or are not) factual assertions or are (or are not) metaphorical or analogical, that terminology used in describing God mean the same (or does not mean the same) as when it is used in describing other things. The philosopher looks at religious beliefs from his vantage position as an epistemologist. Thus one can say that philosophy of religion is the epistemological, ethical, psychological, metaphysical and logical investigation into the nature, grounds and functions of religious faith. Philosophy of religion is entirely a theological enterprise with no concern for the conversion of any one.

The philosopher of religion is concerned primarily with the norms or standard of genuine religion. He examines the principles of religious faith and conditions without which religion cease to be religion. These principles are already implicit in ordinary religious experience, but not consciously recognized as same by the rank and file of believers. It is the task of philosophy of religion to disentangle and categorize these principles. It is necessary to consider whether they are self-consistent and also whether they fit with the general world-view.

One of the main features of religion is that it finds its fullest expression in absolute surrender to the object of worship. But with regard to philosophy, the very existence of that object is main theme. Some philosophers would argue that it is not possible to surrender oneself to what is felt to be an unverified hypothesis. It is not possible to discuss initially the existence of a being to whom one is utterly self-surrendered. The question is then often asked, how can a religious

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person be a free philosopher? By the same token the religious person asks, how can a philosopher who has not yet solved the basic questions of philosophy exercise such unrestricted quest on religion. Archbishop Temple argues that this seeming tension may be partly resolved in the following ways;

- a.) The philosopher must be able to distinguish between the real elements in his faith that of real spiritual importance.
- b.) The philosopher, while accepting the method of science in accounting for experience must also recognize the possible applicability of other categories.
- c.) He must guard against sentimental or traditional religious beliefs which have been crystallized into dogmatism.
- d.) He must recognize the fact that intuitions, a sense of value and personalities are part of the ultimate reality that he wishes to investigate.
- e.) He must concern himself with man's ultimate place in reality while recognizing that there are depths into which reason alone cannot penetrate.

The Enlightenment made the authenticity of the Holy Scripture as a medium of divine revelation come under increasing attack and its authority questioned. Appeal to the miracles reported in the Bible to guarantee the truthfulness of the divine message also proved inadequate. But the discoveries of Newton made many to realize that the universe was governed by natural laws which rendered it self-contained and self-explanatory. Hence, it appeared that Christianity is almost rendered defenseless.

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5.8 Note



“The human spirit is constantly and continuously searching for its source, i.e. God”.

5.9 Questions



- Identify the main arguments of the Feminist theories on Religion.
- What was the explanation of P. Rosario, the Italian theologian, on the origin of religion to human nature itself?
- “If you believe in a non-material God, then you believe that not all that exists is material, and that means you accept a metaphysics of immaterialism”. Discuss.

5.10 Activity



In your religious community, discuss with the female members whether they have ever felt discriminated by their male counterparts and together propose a solution.

5.11 Further reading



Brian Morris, *Anthropological Studies of Religion: An Introductory Text*. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996).

E. Ferguson, *Religions of the World*. (Guildford: Lutterworth, 1978).

Emile Durkheim, *The Elementary Forms of Religious Life*. Trans. J.W. Swain. (London: Allen & Unwin, 1976).

Mircea Eliade, *The Sacred and the Profane*. Trans. W.R. Task. (New York: Harcourt Brace, 1968).

6. RELIGIOUS EXPERIENCE IN ERA OF INTERNET TECHNOLOGY

6.1 Objectives



By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- Understand and be exposed to the role played by internet technology on religious experience in modern society.
- Examine the power of the internet in the changing methods of religious propagation.
- Know why as we go digital, the traditional model of religion is changing.

6.2 Electronic Religion

Religions are presented in the Internet in many ways. There are sites which attempt to cover all religions, traditions, and faiths, such as Patheos (which also provides a forum for atheism/humanism), Religious Tolerance, and Beliefnet, in addition to sites that are specific to a religious traditions, Catholics, Anglicans, Protestants etc. Many sites are discussion groups, others theological debates and some attempt to provide advice concerning religious doctrine.

There are also sites that aim to provide a religious experience facilitating prayer, meditation, or virtual pilgrimages.

There is little doubt that the world is in the midst of fundamental change. “This world of ours is a new world,” wrote Robert Oppenheimer in 1963, “in which the unity of knowledge, the nature of human communities, the order of society, the order of ideas, the very notions of

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society and culture have changed and will not return to what they have been in the past” (*Saturday Review of Literature*, June 29, 1963, p.11).

Thus, it is not enough to call what we are experiencing “rapid social change” or even “revolution”, since these phrase connote only social or political upheaval. The change is more basic in that it modifies everything we have known. As a result, the religions of the world are facing not just a communication revolution but a new Technological Era that brings with it its own world view – one that challenges the world views of all historical religions.

Dutch philosopher Arend van Leewen suggests that there have been only two basic eras in all of history. (1) The first is the ontocratic era in which we have lived until now, in which human society has apprehended life as a cosmic totality, where belief in a God or gods held together the contradictory and confusing elements of the human community. But relatively suddenly – within the past 300 years – we have moved away from this unifying concept into (2) a multiform system of relationships with no single integrating element to give meaning to all other things. We have moved into the technological era, Van Leewen says, and this is the great new fact of our time (*Christianity in a World History* [Edinburgh Press, 1964]). The (a.) communication revolution, the (b.) Age of Information, and the (c.) Information Society are surface manifestations of the more profound change that is under way in every aspect of life.

The technological era is functional and pragmatic, characterized by utilitarianism and relativism. It is thoroughly secular, demanding rationality and personal autonomy, and asserting that this space-time world is the proper home for humankind. It rejects metaphysical claims and demands that religion deal with here and now.

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This secular understanding is not necessarily inconsistent with the Christian faith. The proclamation of the gospel is precisely that “the eternal order” is revealed in “the historical order”. The clash with biblical religion comes only when the technological world view’s emphasis upon the pragmatic and the instrumental results in people’s being treated as means rather than ends.

6.3 Quest For Virtual Community Faith

The rise of the internet led many to claim that a new way exists for overcoming the alienating effects of modern life. Virtual associations could replace the loss of traditional neighborhoods and small personal work environments, and counter the deleterious effects of increasing social and geographic mobility, the impersonal nature of large bureaucratic organizations, and so on. What is more, some argue, the internet facilitates the formation of entirely new kinds of communities – communities that would be free of such limiting factors as ethnic stereotyping, class distinctions, gender discrimination, and differences in time as well as place. People can reach out to each other twenty-four hours a day from almost anywhere in the world (Jones, 1998). “Synchronously and asynchronously,” as Dave Healy states (1997:60), “the sun never sets on the virtual community”.

But has the sun of communal bliss ever really risen on the internet in the first place? The substitution of computer-mediated communication for the face-to-face variety may be symptomatic more of the triumph of modern alienation than of its circumvention. It is important to ask whether “most so-called virtual communities [are not] too specialized, largely ideational in content, and too intermittent or transitory to evoke the sense of we-ness commonly associated

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with the word community (Dawson, 2000: 38). Many observers have suggested that virtual communities are nothing more than pseudo-communities (Lockard, 1997). But until recently we have lacked the empirical data even to begin adjudicating this dispute. In discussions of groups communicating by computer, it is simply assumed too often that “community” is present, without really specifying why or how (Kollock, 1999). Since community implies more than mere social interaction, therefore, not all virtual groups are communities.

At the heart of the debate over virtual communities is a seeming paradox. The internet allows individuals to reach out globally to form bonds with people of like mind, overcoming the physical barriers and social distinctions that have held them apart, but at the price of reducing the self presented and the social interactions established to text-based and largely synchronous exchanges between physically isolated individuals. But it is the dialectical interplay of self and other, surely that forms the basis of true sociality. We tend to presume that greater exposure to real others induces a more sensitive, reflexive, and hence enduring capacity to form communities. How much otherness does one really experience seated alone before a computer screen? Similarly, the internet facilitates “boundary-breaking” interactions (Kinney 1995: 770). People can enter into conversations with people from the most diverse cultures and subcultures, encountering ideas to which they would never be exposed in the daily routines of their lives. But the technologically limited connection provided inevitably attenuates and experience, and our extraordinary ability to control these contacts may render them more solipsistic than we are willing to admit (Willson, 1997). In her ethnography of internet users, Annette Markham found that the ability to control communications, limiting undesired selfdisclosure, was one of the great appeals of communicating by computer (1998: 155-156).

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The online absence of nonverbal social cues, the ones we normally use to judge the character and trustworthiness of people, draws people into a dependence on stereotypes. Both in interpreting others and presenting themselves, Postmes, Spears, and Lea (1998) found that internet users are eager to discover and emulate the norms of any group. In exchanges this means they often fall back on stereotypical conceptions to ease and hasten interaction and gain ready acceptance into desired circles. Socially scripted interactions are used to gloss over the interpretive gaps so typical of strictly text-based exchanges (Kendall, 2002). Is such behavior conducive to the formation of viable communities? Perhaps in the short run. But we need to know if, when and how these communicative short-cuts and preferences will be replaced by more complete and individualized interactions online. Are the technological and cultural biases in favor of quick, witty, truncated, and stereotypical modes of discourse so strong on the internet that more personal and complex discussions are intrinsically and permanently discouraged? Or is this just a dominant feature of certain types of interactions? What prompts more serious and sustained dialogue between people online, and are these interactions almost always less rich than those undertaken in person or by the phone?

As Wellman and Guila (1999: 170) and DiMaggio and colleagues (2001: 319) lament, the right kind of systematic studies of communal life in cyberspace have yet to be completed. We lack either detailed ethnographies of established communities or survey research into who is using the internet in this way and how. We need to know more about the qualitative character of online relationships and the actual performance of so-called virtual communities.

6.4 Effects Of Internet Usage

There have been a number of attempts to create online Christian communities, usually supplementing, but occasionally attempting to replace, more traditional brick and mortar

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Christian communities. It is common for even moderate sized Christian churches with only a few hundred members to have websites;

- a.) To advertise themselves and
- b.) Communicate with their congregations

Many Nairobi Christian communities have websites. For example, Scott Thumma, a faculty associate at the Hartford Institute for Religion Research found that in the U.S. between 1998 and 2002, the ratio of churches with websites went from 11% to 45%. Most sites concentrate on;

- a.) Teaching and discussion
- b.) Experiment with virtual meetings in cyberspace
- c.) Attempt to incorporate teaching, prayer, worship and
- d.) Even music into the experience.

NB: The i-church is the first Internet community to be fully recognized as an Anglican church. Its look and feel are similar to a discussion room. Church of fools is an experimental online site in which worshippers move around a virtual church building using avatars.

After being reassigned to the sinecure diocese of Partenia (a major Algerian city, that was consumed by the Sahara in the 5th century) by Pope John Paul II in 1995 as punishment for his controversial views, Roman Catholic Bishop Jacques Gaillot set up a website for the “diocese without borders”, of “Christ without borders” here in Kenya.

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6.5 Religious Communities Online

If you want to bring people together, so they unite over shared spiritual beliefs, then online social networking is a great place to start. The communities of larger social networking sites are not always friendly to “religious people” and as a result, some feel uncomfortable being a member of a website designed specifically to cater for people who share their beliefs. Anthony Villanueva, the owner of the network for the Bible Baptist Church of Marilao has successfully united the Marilao congregation in an online network.

“We wanted to veer away from a typical “about us” website like most churches have” Anthony reveals, “We wanted a more dynamic and interactive website where members can share, collaborate and update each other even if they’re away.”

So why did Anthony choose SocialGO to build his site? “Being a graphic designer myself, it is important to me that the visual experience of the user is well considered, without sacrificing the usability. I think that’s where SocialGO really stands out.” He explains, going on to illuminate the benefits the service provides his congregation, “It helps make the user/member feel a sense of “exclusivity” belonging to a certain network.” This sense of social inclusion and community is not the only appeal, the numerous practical applications also attract lots of users. “We actually wanted it to be a collaboration tool for churches, where we share resources like (a.) audio sermons, (b.) lessons, (c.) music and (d.) other references.

Anthony is fully aware of the alternatives available but recognizes that they have major drawbacks, “I have tried using a different platform, I’m currently running another social network with Ning and I can say that the level of control and customization in SocialGO is far better”. But its not just his insight as a graphic designer that causes Anthony to favour SocialGO as the

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best social networking platform, his congregation seem keen on it too! “The initial responses of the members were very positive, they’re proud that we have a website that they can really use”

But what are some of the limitations that arise for this kind of religious community?

- a.) When people face the TV/Radio they don’t feel the real presence, e.g. Papal blessings. URBI et ORBI
- b.) Many churches are sacramentally oriented and the signs means a lot to the people e.g. can you baptize on the internet? How about Eucharistic celebrations?

6.6 Note



Many religious communities and congregations are opening websites for their members.

6.7 Questions



- In your neighborhood, how many churches are using the internet and why?
- Compare and contrast the advantages and disadvantages of the use of internet in evangelization.
- By way of examples, show the most effective electronic media in faith groups.

6.8 Activity

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